

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM - Layered Complete Learning Session - Syllabus Item 14

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

BUDDHISM: DEPENDENT PROCESS, NO SUBSTANCE



FOUR SCHOOL ANSWERS TO WHAT IS ULTIMATELY REAL?



Continuity is causal (santana), not substantial; conventional truth preserves ethics and practice.

Concept map for revision; arrows show derivation, not a chronological history of schools.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM - Layered Complete Learning Session - Syllabus Item 14

Syllabus (verbatim): Schools of Buddhism : Prat Ityasaṃutpāda; Kṣāṇikavāda, Nairātmyavāda. **Evidence key:** FACT: canonical doctrine · ANALYSIS: analytical synthesis (for exam use) · CAUTION: contested/uncertain
Placement: A compact syllabus clause with very high conceptual density. UPSC repeatedly uses Buddhism to test causation, self, continuity, liberation, and inter-school differences across Hīnayāna and Mahāyāna.

How to use this layered session

Each logical subtopic follows the Philosophy five-layer sequence:

Layer	Purpose
1. SIMPLE START	Plain-language visual gateway
2. CORE UPSC	Complete retained doctrine, arguments and examples
3. ADVANCED	Objections, replies, comparisons and refinements
4. EXAM APPLICATION	Verified PYQ routing and answer structure
5. RAPID REVISION	Traps, recall spines and mastery preparation

Source audit: the canonical Buddhism knowledge file and complete 2018-2025 PYQ bank were checked. Local OCR-searchable chapters in Chatterjee-Datta (Buddhist chapter beginning at file page 149) and C. D. Sharma (file pages 67-81) were directly inspected. The February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition was rechecked through the High Commission of India in Colombo and is used only as a contemporary conceptual anchor. Qdrant was not required.

Preservation note: every substantive section of the earlier complete session is retained. The new material adds simple gateways and explicit layers without replacing the original depth.

Progress: 1 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Dependent Origination: The Causal and Soteriological Core

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - suffering is a process, not a fate

IGNORANCE
|
conditions craving and clinging
|
becoming, birth, ageing and death

Change the conditions -> change the result.

In simple words: Buddhism asks what keeps suffering happening. If suffering arises because conditions cooperate, it is neither eternal nor imposed by fate. Remove the sustaining conditions and the process can cease.

First idea	Easy meaning
<i>Pratītyasamutpāda</i>	Things arise and cease through conditions
Twelve <i>nidānas</i>	Detailed cycle from ignorance to ageing and death
Middle way	Neither eternal substance nor sheer nothingness
Soteriological point	A conditioned problem can be interrupted

Memory line: because suffering is dependently produced, liberation is causally possible.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

0. ONE-SCREEN MAP

FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS = existential frame

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|
+- duḥkha has a cause -> dependent origination (pratityasamutpāda)
|
|   +- whatever arises dependently lacks self-existence (svabhāva)
|   +- whatever is conditioned is impermanent
|   +- what is called "person" is only a dependently arisen aggregate
|
+- KṢAṆTIKAVĀDA: all conditioned reals are momentary
+- NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA: no permanent ātman/self
+- NIRVĀṆA: cessation of the causal process of suffering
```

FOUR SCHOOLS

Vaibhāṣika -> Sautrāntika -> Yogācāra/Vijñānavāda -> Mādhyamika/Śūnyavāda
direct realism representationalism consciousness-only emptiness of svabhāva

ANALYSIS: **Exam key:** In Buddhism, the three syllabus terms are not separate islands. Dependent origination yields impermanence; impermanence undermines substantial selfhood; no-self reshapes karma, rebirth and nirvāṇa.

1. PRATĪTYASAMUTPĀDA (Pratityasamutpada) — DEPENDENT ORIGINATION

1.1 Statement

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda** means dependent origination: whatever arises, arises depending on causes and conditions; whatever ceases, ceases when those conditions cease.
- FACT: The standard formula, in substance, is: "**imasmiṃ sati idaṃ hoti; imass' uppādā idaṃ uppajjati; imasmiṃ asati idaṃ na hoti; imassa nirodhā idaṃ nirujjhati**" — this being, that becomes; from the arising of this, that arises; this not being, that is not; from the cessation of this, that ceases.
- FACT: It is not merely a cosmological thesis. It is the key to the arising of **duḥkha** and therefore the key to its cessation.

1.2 The Four Noble Truths as the frame

- FACT: Buddhism states the problem first: **duḥkha**.
- FACT: It then identifies a causal structure: duḥkha has an origin.
- FACT: Because the origin is conditioned, it can cease.
- FACT: Therefore a path is possible.
- ANALYSIS: So dependent origination is the philosophical grammar of the Four Noble Truths. The first truth states the fact of suffering; the second gives its dependent arising; the third gives dependent cessation; the fourth is the practical discipline for breaking the chain.

1.3 The twelve nidānas in order

- FACT: The classical chain of dependent origination is expressed through the **dvādaśa-nidāna** sequence:

1. **avidyā** — ignorance
2. **saṃskāra** — formations/dispositions
3. **vijñāna** — consciousness
4. **nāma-rūpa** — name-and-form
5. **ṣaḍāyatana** — six sense-bases
6. **sparsā** — contact
7. **vedanā** — feeling
8. **trṣṇā** — craving
9. **upādāna** — clinging/grasping
10. **bhava** — becoming/existence

11. **jāti** — birth

12. **jarā-maraṇa** — old age and death

- FACT: In visual Buddhist pedagogy, this sequence is often represented through the **bhava-cakra** (wheel of becoming), showing how ignorance and craving keep cyclic existence in motion.

1.4 Argument structure

1. FACT: What is experienced is not self-grounding; it occurs only in dependence.
2. FACT: If a thing were self-existent by its own nature, it would not depend on conditions.
3. FACT: But all conditioned phenomena arise and cease in dependence on conditions.
4. FACT: Therefore conditioned phenomena are neither eternal substances nor sheer nothingness; they are dependent processes.
5. ANALYSIS: The existential point is that suffering too is a process, not a metaphysical fate. Therefore it is removable.

1.5 Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The doctrine presupposes that explanation should be sought through **conditional relations**, not through a static substratum like ātman or Brahman and not through a creator-God standing outside the chain.
- ANALYSIS: It also presupposes that what matters philosophically is not an absolutely first beginning but the structure by which bondage is maintained here and now.

1.6 Distinction: middle way between extremes

- FACT: Buddhism presents dependent origination as the **middle way** between:
- **śāśvatavāda** — eternalism: some enduring self/substance exists unchanged.
- **ucchedavāda** — annihilationism: things are sheer nullities or persons are simply obliterated without causal continuity.
- ANALYSIS: Why is this a middle? Because Buddhism denies permanent substance, yet it also denies that phenomena are sheer nothing. What exists does so dependently.

1.7 Example

- ANALYSIS: A flame persists only because wick, oil, oxygen and ignition remain coordinated. Remove the conditions and the flame ceases. Yet the flame is not absolutely unreal while it burns. This approximates dependent origination better than the language of substance.

1.8 Objection

- CAUTION: If everything depends on something else, does Buddhism explain nothing ultimately? Does it create an infinite regress of conditions?

1.9 Reply

- FACT: Buddhism need not posit an unconditioned substance to make conditioning intelligible. Its primary concern is soteriological: to show that suffering is conditioned and therefore stoppable.
- ANALYSIS: UPSC answers should stress that dependent origination is not a failed search for a first cause; it is a diagnosis of dependent becoming.

1.10 How momentariness follows from dependent origination

- FACT: What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it changes with the rise and fall of those conditions.
- FACT: Therefore what is conditioned is **anitya** (impermanent); Buddhist logicians radicalize this into **kṣaṇikavāda**, according to which what is real is momentary.
- ANALYSIS: Thus a 2019-style answer can move from pratītyasamutpāda to kṣaṇikavāda by arguing: the dependently arisen has no independent enduring essence; it is event-like, not substance-like.

1.11 How 2024's "everything is void" and "everything is real" both arise from pratītyasamutpāda

(a) Mādhyamika: dependent origination implies emptiness

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's central move is that what arises dependently cannot possess **svabhāva** (self-being/own-nature).
- FACT: Therefore all dharmas are **śūnya** — empty of independent essence.
- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is what is called empty.
- ANALYSIS: This does **not** mean sheer non-being; it means lack of intrinsic, self-subsistent reality.

(b) Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika: dependent origination implies conditioned reality

- FACT: The realist Buddhist schools agree that things arise dependently.
- FACT: But instead of inferring emptiness of all dharmas in the Mādhyamika sense, they say: precisely because things arise causally, they are **real as conditioned entities**.
- FACT: Vaibhāṣika treats dharmas as real and directly knowable; Sautrāntika treats them as real though not directly perceived externally.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the same causal thesis can support two ontological emphases: absence of self-nature, or reality of conditioned events.

(c) Distinguishing the two conclusions

School move	What is denied	What is affirmed
Mādhyamika	intrinsic nature (svabhāva)	conventional dependent existence
Vaibhāṣika / Sautrāntika	eternal substance and self	reality of conditioned dharmas

1.12 Cessation and knowledge

- FACT: Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage; insight into it is release.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore the 2023 question — ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation — should be answered not as a mere epistemic slogan, but as a claim that wrong metaphysical grasping fuels craving and hence suffering.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced derivation and school divergence

Dependent origination is not a search for the universe's first cause. It diagnoses the structure of conditioned becoming here and now. This avoids eternalism because no unchanged self grounds the process, and avoids annihilationism because causal continuity remains.

The doctrine supports different ontological conclusions. Mādhyamika argues that whatever depends on conditions lacks *svabhāva* and is therefore empty. Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika instead emphasise that causally functioning conditioned events are real. Their disagreement concerns ultimate status, not whether dependent arising occurs.

The strongest challenge is regress: if every event is conditioned, what explains the chain as a whole? The Buddhist reply is therapeutic and structural rather than foundational—the task is to identify and cease the conditions of suffering, not posit an unconditioned creator-substance.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2018 Q5(b), 10 marks:** derive *śūnyatā* from dependent origination without equating emptiness with non-being.
- **2019 Q7(c), 15 marks** and **2020 Q6(a), 20 marks:** show how dependence and causal change lead to momentariness.
- **2023 Q8(a), 20 marks:** connect ignorance of the chain to suffering and insight into the chain to cessation.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** compare the realist and Mādhyamika conclusions from the same causal doctrine.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Standard pattern: this being, that arises; this ceasing, that ceases.
- Twelve links run from ignorance to ageing and death.
- *Pratītyasamutpāda* is causal, existential and soteriological.
- Middle way: causal continuity without permanent substance.
- Trap: dependent origination is not fatalism; conditions can be altered.

Progress: 2 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Kṣaṇikavāda: Momentariness, Causal Efficiency and Continuity

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - the flame is a stream of events

flame 1 -> flame 2 -> flame 3
similar and causally connected
but not one numerically unchanged flame

continuity = series, not permanent substance

In simple words: what looks like one lasting thing may be a rapidly connected sequence. Each moment performs its causal work and gives rise to the next.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Kṣaṇikavāda</i>	Conditioned reality is momentary
<i>Arthakriyā</i>	Capacity to produce an effect
<i>Santāna</i>	Causal continuum
Recognition	Similarity within a stream, according to Buddhism

Memory line: what is real acts; what acts does so in a changing causal moment.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

2. KṢAṆIKAVĀDA (Ksanikavada) — DOCTRINE OF MOMENTARINESS

2.1 Statement

- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda** holds that whatever is real is momentary.
- FACT: A standard scholastic formulation runs in substance as: **whatever is truly real is momentary** (*sattve satyeva kṣaṇikatvam*).
- ANALYSIS: The doctrine is not that nothing exists; it is that reality is evental rather than substantial.

2.2 Argument from causal efficiency (arthakriyākāritva)

Statement

- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva** (causal efficacy / capacity to perform a function) is the Buddhist pramāṇa-school criterion of the real: **sat = arthakriyā-samartha** — the real is what is capable of producing an effect.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda** follows because whatever is causally effective must be moment-specific; a wholly permanent entity cannot explain why an effect appears now rather than always.
- ANALYSIS: This is the bridge between Buddhist epistemology and ontology: the same test that ranks **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular) as ultimately real also grounds the thesis **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam** — whatever is real is momentary.

Argument

1. FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious; an entity that makes no difference is indistinguishable from a non-entity for Buddhist analysis.
2. FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either **simultaneously** or **successively**.
3. FACT: If a permanent entity produces its effect all at once, nothing remains for later production; this is the **yaugapadya** (simultaneity) horn.
4. FACT: If it produces effects successively, then it functions differently at different moments; what functions differently is not wholly permanent. This is the **krama** (succession) horn.
5. FACT: If Nyāya says it acts only when auxiliary conditions (**sahakārin**, helper-conditions) are present, the Buddhist reply is the **sahakāri-anapekṣā** dilemma: either the permanent thing already has the power and does not need auxiliaries, or the decisive causal power lies in the changing auxiliaries rather than in the permanent thing.
6. FACT: Therefore a permanent entity cannot coherently be causally efficient.
7. FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary: **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The argument presupposes a pragmatic-realist criterion: reality is not inert self-identity but effect-producing capacity.
- ANALYSIS: It also presupposes that a single unchanged entity cannot have genuinely different causal profiles at different times without ceasing to be unchanged.

Distinction

Issue	FACT: Buddhist logician	FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika opponent
Test of reality	FACT: causal efficacy (arthakriyā)	FACT: substance, quality, action, universal, inherence and absence as categories
Enduring thing	FACT: only a conventional series	FACT: real substance enduring through changing qualities
Effect at different times	FACT: requires momentary causal phases	FACT: explained by auxiliary conditions acting on an enduring substance

Example

- ANALYSIS: A seed is real because it can issue in a sprout. But the seed that has exercised that precise sprout-producing capacity is no longer the same causal phase; the series has advanced.

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: Nyāya asks: why can a permanent substance not act at one time because relevant auxiliary conditions are then present?
- FACT: Nyāya also uses **pratyabhijñā** (recognition — “this is that same jar”), memory and moral desert to argue that enduring substances and selves are required.

Reply — Buddhist logicians

- FACT: The Buddhist reply is that if the permanent thing remains wholly unchanged, then the decisive factor lies elsewhere; its own efficacy is redundant.
- FACT: Recognition is explained through **sādrśya** (similarity) within a causal stream, not strict numerical identity.
- FACT: Memory and desert are explained through **santāna / santati** (causal continuum), with **ālaya-vijñāna** and **bīja** (seeds) supplying the Yogācāra version of the continuity device.
- ANALYSIS: The Nyāya rejoinder retains force: a mere series seems unable to own memories or deserts unless something owns the series.

2.3 Argument from destruction (vināśitvānumāna / kṣaṇabhaṅga line)

- FACT: Another line of reasoning holds that destruction does not require a second, separate destroyer added from outside.
- FACT: The very nature of the conditioned is to perish; arising already contains ceasing.

- ANALYSIS: Hence things are not first fully stable entities and later destroyed; their transience belongs to what they are.

2.4 Apparent continuity: **santāna**

- FACT: If everything is momentary, why does the world look continuous?
- FACT: Buddhism answers through **santāna** — a causal series or stream.
- FACT: Each moment gives rise to the next sufficiently similar moment, producing the appearance of persistence.
- FACT: Standard illustrations are a **flame** or a **stream**: continuity without strict identity.

2.5 Memory and personal identity under momentariness (2021)

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: If every mental state perishes instantly, then who remembers a past event?
- FACT: If the rememberer is numerically different from the experiencer, how can there be personal identity or moral responsibility?

Buddhist replies

1. FACT: **Santāna**: memory belongs to the same causal stream, not to a permanent self.
2. FACT: **Pratisandhāna**: reconnection/relinking explains continuity across moments and lives.
3. FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna** in Yogācāra: a store-consciousness carries latent impressions (**bīja**, seeds), explaining the preservation of karmic and mnemonic potential.

Philosophical point

- ANALYSIS: The Buddhist answer is deliberately middle-path: the later subject is neither strictly the same nor wholly other than the earlier one.

2.6 Karma without a self (2022)

Problem

- FACT: Karma seems to require a persisting moral subject: the doer should receive the fruit.

Buddhist answer

- FACT: The stream receives the fruit of what the earlier stream-stage performed.
- FACT: The relation is **neither identity nor utter difference**.
- ANALYSIS: If it were strict identity, Buddhism would collapse into eternalism; if it were total difference, responsibility would collapse. The doctrine of series protects moral continuity without substantial selfhood.

2.7 Example

- ANALYSIS: One lamp lights another. The second flame is not numerically the first, yet it is causally connected to it. Rebirth and karmic fruition are often explained analogically in this way.

2.8 Objection — Nyāya pratyabhijñā argument

- CAUTION: Recognition such as "this is the same person I met before" appears to require enduring identity, not merely stream-likeness.

2.9 Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can say recognition tracks practical continuity and similarity within a series, not metaphysical identity of a substance.
- ANALYSIS: The language of sameness belongs to conventional truth; ultimate analysis reveals only a flow of conditioned moments.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced argument and Nyāya pressure

The causal-efficiency argument asks how a wholly permanent cause could produce effects at different times. If its complete power operates immediately, all effects should appear together; if it produces successively, its causal profile changes and it is not wholly permanent. Auxiliary conditions do not automatically save permanence: if they make the decisive difference, the unchanged cause appears redundant.

Nyāya's reply remains powerful. An enduring substance may act when the required conditions arrive, while recognition—"this is that"—memory and moral ownership seem to presuppose numerical identity. Buddhism answers with similarity, causal transmission, seeds and, in Yogācāra, *ālaya-vijñāna*.

The residual issue is ownership. A stream can transmit information and karmic effects, but critics ask what makes it *one person's* stream rather than merely a sequence externally described as one.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- Reconstruct *arthakriyākāritva* before stating momentariness.
- Use the simultaneity/succession dilemma and address auxiliary conditions.
- **2021 Q7(b), 15 marks:** explain memory and identity through causal continuity, similarity and seeds, then concede the ownership objection.
- **2022 Q6(a), 20 marks:** apply the same stream model to karma and moral continuity.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Formula: whatever is real is momentary.
- Reality test: causal efficacy.
- Two horns for a permanent cause: simultaneous effects or changing succession.
- Continuity device: *santāna/santati*, not permanent identity.
- Trap: momentariness does not mean causal disconnectedness.

Progress: 3 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Nairātmyavāda: Five Aggregates, Karma and Nirvāṇa Without a Soul

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - person as an organised process

BODY + FEELING + RECOGNITION
+ DISPOSITIONS + CONSCIOUSNESS
|
v
conventionally called "person"

No extra permanent owner is found.

In simple words: Buddhism does not deny everyday persons. It denies an additional unchanging self behind the five aggregates. The person is a dependently organised causal process.

Aggregate	Easy meaning
<i>Rūpa</i>	Material form
<i>Vedanā</i>	Feeling
<i>Samjñā</i>	Recognition or designation
<i>Samskāra</i>	Dispositions and formations

Aggregate	Easy meaning
<i>Vijñāna</i>	Consciousness

Memory line: conventional personhood remains; permanent substance-self is rejected.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

3. NAIRĀTMYAVĀDA (Nairatmyavada) — NO-SELF DOCTRINE

3.1 Statement

- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda** or **anātmavāda** denies a permanent, unchanging ātman behind experience.
- FACT: What is conventionally called a person is only an aggregate of changing factors.

3.2 The five skandhas

- FACT: The person is analysed into five **skandhas**:
 1. **rūpa** — form/material body
 2. **vedanā** — feeling/sensation
 3. **saṃjñā** — perception/recognition
 4. **saṃskāra** — dispositions/formations
 5. **vijñāna** — consciousness
- ANALYSIS: The philosophical force of the doctrine lies in exhaustive analysis: if what we call self reduces to these aggregates and no extra owner is found, the self is a conceptual imputation, not an independently real substance.

3.3 Chariot analogy (Milinda-pañha)

- FACT: The classic **chariot analogy** argues that "chariot" is merely a name for the arrangement of axle, wheels, yoke and other parts.
- FACT: Likewise, "person" is a conventional designation for the aggregate of skandhas.
- ANALYSIS: The point is not that the person is uselessly unreal. It is that the person is conventionally valid but not ultimately self-subsistent.

3.4 Pudgala-nairātmya and dharma-nairātmya (2021)

Pudgala-nairātmya

- FACT: Denial of a permanent personal self (**pudgala**, person).
- FACT: This is the minimum no-self thesis common to Buddhism.

Dharma-nairātmya

- FACT: Denial that even dharmas possess intrinsic self-nature.
- FACT: This is developed most strongly in Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika.

School difference

- FACT: **Hīnayāna / early realist schools**: primarily affirm **pudgala-nairātmya**; dharmas are treated as real.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna**: affirms both **pudgala-nairātmya** and **dharma-nairātmya**; neither person nor dharma has svabhāva.

Distinction table

Thesis	What is denied	Who strongly stresses it
Pudgala-nairātmya	enduring person/self	all Buddhism
Dharma-nairātmya	intrinsic nature of dharmas	Mahāyāna, especially Mādhyamika

3.5 The Puggalavāda foil

- FACT: Some Buddhist groups, often associated with the **Vātsīputrīyas**, proposed a **pudgala** that is neither the same as nor different from the skandhas.
- FACT: Mainstream Buddhists criticized this as a relapse toward self-theory.
- ANALYSIS: In answers, use Puggalavāda as a foil: it shows that the pressure to preserve moral continuity was real, but orthodox Buddhist thought refused to answer it by reintroducing a substantial person.

3.6 Triratna and no-self (2022)

Problem

- FACT: If there is no self, who takes refuge in the **Triratna** — Buddha, Dharma, Saṅgha?

Reply

- FACT: Buddhism can answer: the refuge-taker is the **conventional person**, a **prajñapti-puruṣa** or designated person, not an ultimately real soul.
- FACT: Ethical and spiritual practice proceeds at the level of conventional truth without requiring metaphysical ātman.
- ANALYSIS: Thus anātman does not abolish discipline; it purifies it of ego-metaphysics.

3.7 Nirvāṇa

- FACT: **Nirvāṇa** is the cessation of suffering and the extinguishing of the three fires: **rāga** (attachment), **dveṣa** (aversion), and **moha** (delusion).
- FACT: It is not best understood as a substantial place or eternal self-state gained by an entity.
- ANALYSIS: It is the cessation of the very process that produces bondage.

3.8 Is nirvāṇa consistent with kṣaṇikavāda and nairātmyavāda? (2025)

Objection — Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya realist

- FACT: If there is no self, who attains nirvāṇa?
- FACT: If everything is momentary, what persists in liberation?

Reply

1. FACT: The question "who attains?" assumes the very self Buddhism rejects.
2. FACT: Nirvāṇa is not an entity possessed by a soul.
3. FACT: It is the cessation of craving, ignorance and the suffering-series grounded in them.
4. ANALYSIS: So consonance exists: no-self removes the false claimant to liberation; momentariness explains why the chain can in fact cease.

Theravāda and Mahāyāna nuance

- FACT: **Theravāda**: emphasizes individual **nibbāna** and the arhat ideal.
- FACT: **Mahāyāna**: emphasizes the bodhisattva ideal and universal liberation.
- FACT: In Nāgārjuna's radical language, **saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms**; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced compatibility problem

The chariot analogy shows that a person is designated upon organised components and relations; no separate chariot-substance or person-substance must be added. Early Buddhism primarily denies *pudgala-ātman*, while Mahāyāna extends emptiness to dharmas themselves.

Karma without self avoids both strict identity and complete difference: the later recipient is neither numerically identical to nor causally disconnected from the earlier agent. This middle position preserves transmission but remains vulnerable to the moral-ownership objection.

Nirvāṇa is not the immortality of an ego and not the destruction of an eternal person. It is cessation of greed, hatred, delusion and the conditioned production of suffering. Theravāda may distinguish the unconditioned from momentary conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamika avoids reifying nirvāṇa as a separate substance by reading saṃsāra and nirvāṇa through emptiness.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2018 Q6(b), 15 marks** and **2025 Q8(c), 15 marks:** establish compatibility by distinguishing cessation of process from destruction of a permanent self.
- **2020 Q7(b), 15 marks:** use the five aggregates and chariot analogy, then define liberation without importing Vedānta.
- **2021 Q5(d), 10 marks:** distinguish personal no-self from Mahāyāna's no-self of dharmas.
- **2022 Q7(b), 15 marks:** explain how the three jewels guide a path without presupposing an eternal practitioner.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Five aggregates, no sixth permanent owner.
- *Pudgala-nairātmya*: no substantial person.
- *Dharma-nairātmya*: no intrinsic nature in dharmas.
- Karma continues through a causal stream.
- Nirvāṇa is cessation without an eternal possessor.

Progress: 4 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: The Four Schools and Buddhist Arguments Against a Creator

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - four answers to what is ultimately real

VAIBHASIKA : external dharmas directly known
 SAUTRANTIKA : external dharmas inferred from representations
 YOGACARA : cognitive process, not independent external object
 MADHYAMIKA : no dharma has intrinsic self-nature

In simple words: the schools share impermanence and no-self but disagree about external objects, consciousness and the ultimate status of dharmas.

School	Recall label
Vaibhāṣika	Direct realism
Sautrāntika	Representational or inferential realism
Yogācāra	Consciousness-only analysis
Mādhyamika	Emptiness of intrinsic nature

Memory line: direct object -> inferred object -> cognition-only -> emptiness of every fixed position.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

4. THE FOUR SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

4.1 Vaibhāṣika

- FACT: Usually associated with **Sarvāstivāda** realism.
- FACT: Holds **bāhya-pratyakṣa-vāda**: external objects are directly perceived.
- FACT: Affirms **sarvam asti** in the technical sense that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence.

Philosophical significance

- ANALYSIS: Vaibhāṣika preserves Buddhist anti-self doctrine while still maintaining a robust realism about dharmas.
- ANALYSIS: It is therefore a useful contrast both to Yogācāra idealism and to Mādhyamika anti-essentialism.

4.2 Sautrāntika

- FACT: Holds **bāhyānumeya-vāda**: external objects exist, but are known only inferentially through mental representations.
- FACT: Rejects the Sarvāstivāda thesis that past and future dharmas exist in the same sense as present ones.
- FACT: Strongly privileges the present moment.

Distinction from Vaibhāṣika

Issue	Vaibhāṣika	Sautrāntika
External object	real	real
How known	directly perceived	inferentially known via representation
Temporal ontology	past-present-future dharmas exist	only present dharmas fully exist

4.3 Yogācāra / Vijñānavāda

Statement

- FACT: Yogācāra advances **vijñaptimātra** or consciousness-only.
- FACT: What appears as external object is inseparable from modes of consciousness.

Key doctrine: ālaya-vijñāna

- FACT: The **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) preserves karmic seeds (**bījas**), explaining continuity, memory and rebirth without a permanent self.

Arguments against external realism

1. FACT: **Dream argument**: dream-objects are vividly experienced despite lacking corresponding external objects; therefore experienced objecthood does not prove external independent matter.
2. FACT: **Atom critique**: if atoms are partless, they cannot combine spatially; if they have parts, they are not ultimate atoms. Hence external atomism is unstable.

Tri-svabhāva (three natures)

- FACT: **parikalpita-svabhāva** — imagined nature
- FACT: **paratantra-svabhāva** — dependent nature
- FACT: **pariṇiṣpanna-svabhāva** — perfected/consummate nature
- ANALYSIS: These explain how deluded objectification arises and how it is overcome.

4.4 Mādhyamika / Śūnyavāda

Statement

- FACT: Associated especially with **Nāgārjuna**.
- FACT: The central thesis is **śūnyatā** (emptiness): absence of **svabhāva** (intrinsic nature / own-being), not sheer nothingness.

- FACT: In substance, Nāgārjuna identifies dependent origination and emptiness: what is dependently arisen is empty of independent essence.

Catuṣkoṭi — the four corners

Corner	Sanskrit	FACT: Basic claim
1	asti	FACT: It is.
2	nāsti	FACT: It is not.
3	asti ca nāsti ca	FACT: It both is and is not.
4	naivāsti naiva nāsti	FACT: It neither is nor is not.

- FACT: **Early / Nikāya use:** the avyākata / avyākṛta questions are often framed through four alternatives, and all four are set aside because they do not conduce to liberation and rest on misleading presuppositions.
- FACT: **Madhyamaka use:** Nāgārjuna negates all four alternatives when they are applied to things imagined as possessing **svabhāva**.
- ANALYSIS: Thus the early use is primarily therapeutic and soteriological; the Madhyamaka use is also logical-ontological, because it exposes the incoherence of intrinsic nature.

Crucial logical nuance — why this is not simple contradiction

- FACT: Madhyamaka negation is best read as **prasajya-pratiśedha** (non-implicative / commitment-free negation), not **paryudāsa-pratiśedha** (implicative negation that asserts a positive alternative).
- FACT: The four corners are denied **of things taken as having svabhāva**; once svabhāva is dropped, the denial does not install a fifth positive thesis.
- FACT: Hence Nāgārjuna can claim, in the spirit of the *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, that he has no independent **pratijñā** (thesis) of his own.
- ANALYSIS: This means: “I deny that x has intrinsic nature” is not meant to assert a new metaphysical substrate called emptiness.

Two truths as the anti-nihilist frame

Truth	FACT: Meaning	ANALYSIS: Exam use
saṃvṛti-satya	FACT: Conventional truth: language, persons, karma, compassion and practice function dependently.	ANALYSIS: Prevents Madhyamaka from abolishing ordinary discourse.
paramārtha-satya	FACT: Ultimate truth: no dharma possesses svabhāva.	ANALYSIS: Prevents conventional truth from being mistaken for substance.

- FACT: Conventional truth is not mere falsehood; it is the domain within which practical life and Buddhist discipline function.
- FACT: Ultimate truth is insight into the emptiness of all reified positions.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna warns that emptiness wrongly grasped destroys the dull-witted, like a snake wrongly seized.
- ANALYSIS: The two-truths doctrine keeps catuṣkoṭi from collapsing into nihilism: conventional functioning is preserved, ultimate intrinsic being is denied.

Objection — Nyāya / Uddyotakara-type and modern irrationalism charge

- FACT: The opponent says: if all four alternatives are denied, the Mādhyamika either says nothing or contradicts himself.
- FACT: The opponent adds: the denial itself is a thesis, so the claim “I have no thesis” is self-refuting.

Reply — Nāgārjuna and later Madhyamaka

- FACT: Nāgārjuna's reply is the “my words are empty too” move: his statements do not possess svabhāva and therefore do not create a positive ontological commitment.
- FACT: The traditional image is that one magically created person (**nirmitaka**) may counteract another magically created person; similarly, empty words may cure empty reifications.

- FACT: The Mādhyamika uses arguments as medicine, not as a new metaphysical substance.
- ANALYSIS: Whether this reply fully succeeds is genuinely debated.
- CAUTION: The **Prāsaṅgika / Svātantrika** split marks this debate internally: **Candrakīrti** is associated with using reductio (**prasaṅga**) without independent syllogisms, while **Bhāvaviveka** allows independent (**svatantra**) inferences in debate.

Śūnyatā is not nihilism

- FACT: To say things are empty is to say they lack **svabhāva**.
- FACT: It is not to say they are absent in every sense.
- FACT: Since conventional truth remains operative, compassion, karma and the path are not denied.
- ANALYSIS: Emptiness undercuts metaphysical grasping, not dependent functioning.

5. BUDDHIST ARGUMENTS AGAINST A CREATOR GOD

ANALYSIS: This is a cross-paper theme and should be linked with Proofs for God and Religion without God.

5.1 Core lines of criticism

- FACT: If God is eternal and unchanging, genuine creation becomes difficult to explain, because willing or producing seems to involve change.
- FACT: If God creates from desire or purpose, that suggests lack, preference or incompleteness.
- FACT: The presence of suffering and evil sits uneasily with an omnipotent benevolent creator.
- FACT: Dependent origination already explains the arising of phenomena through conditions, making a creator unnecessary.

5.2 Philosophical force

- ANALYSIS: Buddhist critique is not mere atheistic denial; it is a systematic refusal of explanatory surplus. If conditioned arising explains the world-process, God is not needed.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced distinctions and anti-nihilist safeguards

Yogācāra should not be equated casually with Advaita. Its *ālaya-vijñāna* is a conditioned stream carrying seeds, not an eternal Brahman or creator consciousness. The three natures distinguish imagined duality, dependent cognitive process and the perfected absence of that duality.

Mādhyamika's *catuṣkoṭi* is a dialectical test of reified alternatives, not a licence to assert contradictions. The two truths preserve conventional causation and practice while denying intrinsic nature ultimately. "Emptiness of emptiness" blocks the transformation of *śūnyatā* into a new Absolute.

Buddhist criticism of a creator stresses explanatory redundancy, the incompatibility of immutable agency with temporal action, and the moral problem of suffering. Dependent origination supplies a non-theistic causal alternative without claiming that events are uncaused.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- **2019 Q5(b), 10 marks:** explain Yogācāra's denial of independently external objects using representations, dreams, seeds and the three natures.
- **2024 Q6(b), 15 marks:** contrast realist dharmas with Mādhyamika emptiness while preserving their shared causal starting point.
- Use a four-school matrix rather than four disconnected paragraphs.
- Never write "Yogācāra = Advaita" or "Mādhyamika = nihilism".

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Vaibhāṣika: direct external realism.
- Sautrāntika: external cause inferred from representation.
- Yogācāra: *ālaya-vijñāna*, seeds and three natures.
- Mādhyamika: *śūnyatā*, two truths, *catuṣkoṭi*.
- No creator is required because conditioned causation performs the explanatory work.

Progress: 5 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Inter-School Debates and Named Criticism-Reply Chains

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - where rivals apply pressure

NYAYA	-> memory and recognition need an enduring self
MIMAMSA	-> knowledge and universals need stable bearers
ADVAITA	-> liberation is unintelligible without reality/self
CARVAKA	-> no-self is bodily reduction
BUDDHISM	-> causal continuity replaces permanent substance

In simple words: Buddhist process theory solves some problems created by substance, but rivals ask whether a process can remember, act, deserve consequences and attain liberation without an owner.

Memory line: every debate turns on whether causal continuity can perform the work of identity.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

6. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

Debate axis	Buddhist position	Rival / internal contrast
Causation	dependent origination	Nyāya's ārambhavāda; Sāṃkhya's satkāryavāda
Persistence	momentary stream	Nyāya substance with changing qualities
Self	no permanent ātman	Nyāya, Vedānta, Jainism affirm self/jīva
External world	varies by school	Vaibhāṣika realism, Yogācāra idealism, Mādhyamika anti-essentialism
Nirvāṇa	cessation of duḥkha-process	Vedāntic mokṣa as self-realization
God	unnecessary / philosophically problematic	Nyāya theism

6.1 Carvāka's rejection of self vs Buddhist rejection of ātman (2024)

- FACT: **Carvāka** denies self beyond body and tends toward materialist reduction.
- FACT: **Buddhism** denies permanent self but does not reduce personhood simply to gross body; it analyses the person into skandhas and preserves karmic continuity without substance.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore both reject an eternal ātman, but for very different reasons and with very different moral-metaphysical consequences.

6.2 Internal Buddhist pūrvapakṣa chain — how the four schools answer one another

Stage	FACT: Siddhānta claimed	ANALYSIS: Becomes pūrvapakṣa for	FACT: Next Buddhist reply
Vaibhāṣika / Sarvāstivāda	FACT: Dharmas are real and, in the Sarvāstivāda sense, have existence across past, present and future.	ANALYSIS: Sautrāntika objects that this weakens momentariness and overpopulates ontology.	FACT: Only the present moment is fully operative; external objects are inferred through representations.
Sautrāntika	FACT: External objects exist but are known inferentially, not directly.	ANALYSIS: Yogācāra objects that an inferred external object is unnecessary because all that is given is cognition.	FACT: Vijñapti-mātra (representation-only): objecthood is inseparable from consciousness-appearance.
Yogācāra	FACT: Consciousness-only explains appearance, karma and continuity through ālaya-vijñāna .	ANALYSIS: Madhyamaka objects that consciousness is being reified as a subtle substance.	FACT: Even consciousness lacks svabhāva ; all dharmas are empty.
Madhyamaka	FACT: Śūnyatā prevents every reification, including reification of emptiness.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Advaita object that this risks nihilism or self-refutation.	FACT: Two truths preserve conventional practice while ultimate analysis denies intrinsic nature.

- ANALYSIS: **Exam payoff**: for “Schools of Buddhism”, do not list four schools mechanically. Present them as an argumentative escalation: realism of dharmas -> presentist representationalism -> idealist consciousness-only -> anti-essentialist emptiness.

7. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES — NAMED PŪRVAPAKṢA

7.1 Nyāya criticism: memory, recognition and moral desert require a permanent self

Objection — Nyāya (Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana line)

- FACT: **Pratyabhijñā** (recognition) — “this is that same jar” or “I am the same person who saw before” — appears to disclose identity through time.
- FACT: Memory seems to require that the subject who remembers be identical with the subject who experienced.
- FACT: Moral desert seems to require an enduring agent: the doer of an act must be the enjoyer or sufferer of its fruit.

Reply — Buddhist schools

- FACT: **Santāna / santati** (causal series) explains continuity without an identical substance.
- FACT: **Sādrśya** (similarity) explains why recognition mistakes a later similar causal phase for the numerically same object.
- FACT: The flame and river examples show continuity without strict identity: a later flame or river-stage is neither wholly the same nor wholly other.
- FACT: Yogācāra adds **ālaya-vijñāna** (store-consciousness) and **bīja** (seeds) as the carrier of karmic and mnemonic potential without accepting an ātman.
- ANALYSIS: Nyāya's residual force: a series may explain causal succession, but it is less clear how a series can “own” memories unless some subject owns the series.

7.2 Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa and Mīmāṃsā criticism: pramāṇa supports self and universals

Objection — Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa

- FACT: Mīmāṃsā defends a persisting self as the subject of cognition, duty, memory and Vedic action.
- FACT: Kumāṛila also resists **apoha** by arguing that general words and recognition require positive universals, not merely exclusion.
- FACT: A merely negative meaning such as “not-non-cow” seems unable to explain the positive cognition “cow”.

Reply — Buddhist pramāṇa school

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reduce the self to a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions.

- FACT: Apoha explains generality as exclusion grounded in causal convergence: many distinct particulars produce the same practical judgment and action, so a concept is formed without a real universal.
- ANALYSIS: Residual force remains: critics argue that the exclusion must already know what to exclude, making apoha circular.

7.3 Śaṅkara / Advaita criticism: momentariness and emptiness make liberation unintelligible

Objection — Śaṅkara-type Advaita

- FACT: If everything is momentary, bondage and liberation cannot belong to one continuing subject.
- FACT: If there is no self, the unity of the knower is unintelligible.
- FACT: If **śūnyatā** is ultimate, the very denial seems to presuppose a self-luminous witnessing consciousness that makes denial possible.

Reply — Buddhist two-truths response

- FACT: Buddhism denies that liberation requires an eternal witness; liberation is the cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation in a causal stream.
- FACT: At **saṃvṛti-satya** (conventional truth), persons, practice and compassion are valid designations.
- FACT: At **paramārtha-satya** (ultimate truth), neither person nor witness has intrinsic nature.
- ANALYSIS: The Advaitin's residual force is that Buddhist analysis must explain the unity of experience without quietly importing a witness.

7.4 Nyāya / realist criticism: emptiness collapses into nihilism

Objection — Nyāya and common realist charge

- FACT: If all dharmas are empty, nothing seems to remain for knowledge, ethics or liberation.
- FACT: If the Mādhyamika denies all theses, the denial appears self-refuting.

Reply — Madhyamaka

- FACT: Emptiness means emptiness of own-being, not absence of dependent functioning.
- FACT: The two truths preserve conventional causation, karma and path-practice while denying intrinsic nature.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna's "empty words" strategy treats philosophical utterance as a therapeutic instrument rather than a final ontology.
- ANALYSIS: Residual force remains in the debate over whether non-implicative negation can avoid becoming a thesis.

7.5 Criticism: karma without self is unjust

Objection — Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta

- FACT: If doer and enjoyer are not strictly identical, moral desert appears to disappear.
- FACT: If they are strictly different, punishment or reward would fall on another.

Reply — Buddhist middle position

- FACT: Buddhism rejects both strict identity and strict difference.
- FACT: The stream that receives the fruit is causally continuous with the stream-stage that acted.
- FACT: This avoids eternalism while preserving moral responsibility at the conventional level.
- ANALYSIS: The unresolved pressure is whether causal continuity alone is enough for desert, rather than merely for causal explanation.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced dialectical verdict

Nyāya's recognition and memory objections target ownership rather than mere transmission. Buddhist stream theories explain how traces continue, but the critic asks who recognises or deserves. Mīmāṃsā adds a semantic challenge: *apoha* may explain exclusion but appears to presuppose positive similarity.

Advaita criticism presses the soteriological cost of emptiness and momentariness. The Buddhist response distinguishes conventional path and ultimate non-reification; liberation is transformation and cessation within the process, not discovery of an eternal witness.

Cārvāka and Buddhism both reject a transcendent self, but Cārvāka identifies the person with the conscious body while Buddhism analyses body and mind into a causal aggregate-stream. The disagreement is therefore material identity versus process ontology.

A balanced verdict concedes that Buddhism offers a sophisticated non-substantialist model while leaving a real philosophical burden concerning first-person unity and moral ownership.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

Use a dialectic grid: **named opponent -> exact target -> Buddhist reply -> residual pressure.**

For memory, karma and liberation questions, never answer with the word *santāna* alone. Explain causal transmission, similarity, seeds or store-consciousness, then assess whether transmission adequately supplies ownership.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Nyāya: recognition, memory and desert.
- Mīmāṃsā: positive universals and stable cognition.
- Advaita: subject and liberation.
- Buddhist reply: continuity without identity.
- Residual problem: a stream may transmit effects yet still seem to lack an owner.

Progress: 6 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: UPSC Traps, Keyword Control and the Restored Doctrine Dossier

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - four equations to avoid

NO-SELF	!= no conventional person
EMPTINESS	!= nothing exists
MOMENTARINESS	!= causal chaos
NIRVANA	!= immortal ego or simple annihilation

In simple words: most weak answers fail through category errors rather than missing facts. Define what a doctrine denies and what it still preserves.

Memory line: Buddhism removes intrinsic substance while retaining conditioned function.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

8. COMMON UPSC TRAPS

- ANALYSIS: **Trap 1:** treating pratīyasamutpāda as a simple linear cosmology. It is primarily a doctrine of dependent suffering and cessation.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 2:** saying momentariness means non-existence. Buddhism says the real conditioned is momentary, not unreal in every sense.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 3:** confusing **pudgala-nairātmya** with **dharma-nairātmya**.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 4:** writing that all Buddhist schools say the same thing about the external world. They do not.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 5:** calling śūnyatā nihilism. Mādhyamika explicitly resists that reading.

- ANALYSIS: **Trap 6:** saying Triratna is inconsistent with no-self because "nobody remains to practise." Buddhism admits a conventional person.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 7:** answering karma-under-momentariness by smuggling in a hidden soul. The correct device is **santāna**, not ātman.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 8:** treating catuṣkoṭi as a denial of logic. The Madhyamaka point is non-implicative negation of svabhāva, not casual contradiction.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 9:** writing that Buddhist pramāṇa theory is just Nyāya logic with fewer pramāṇas. It rests on momentary particulars, apoha and no enduring knower.
- ANALYSIS: **Trap 10:** confusing Jain non-absolutism with Buddhist no-substance. Jainism preserves jīva and dravya; Buddhism denies self-substance.

9. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

- FACT: **Pratītyasamutpāda:** dependent origination; this being, that becomes.
- FACT: **Dvādaśa-nidāna:** twelve links of conditioned becoming.
- FACT: **Kṣaṇikavāda:** whatever is real is momentary.
- FACT: **Arthakriyākāritva:** reality as causal efficiency.
- FACT: **Santāna:** causal stream/continuum.
- FACT: **Nairātmyavāda / anātman:** denial of permanent self.
- FACT: **Skandhas:** rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna.
- FACT: **Pudgala-nairātmya:** no personal self.
- FACT: **Dharma-nairātmya:** no self-nature in dharmas.
- FACT: **Vijñaptimātra:** consciousness-only.
- FACT: **Ālaya-vijñāna:** store-consciousness carrying seeds.
- FACT: **Śūnyatā:** emptiness of svabhāva.
- FACT: **Samvṛti / paramārtha:** conventional / ultimate truth.
- FACT: **Avyākata / avyākṛta:** undeclared questions set aside as non-conducive and presuppositionally defective.
- FACT: **Catuṣkoṭi:** four alternatives — is, is-not, both, neither — denied when applied to svabhāva.
- FACT: **Pramāṇa:** valid means of knowledge; Buddhist epistemologists reduce these to perception and inference.
- FACT: **Pratyakṣa / anumāna:** perception of unique particular / inference of conceptual general character.
- FACT: **Svalakṣaṇa / sāmānyalakṣaṇa:** unique causal particular / constructed general character.
- FACT: **Kalpanāpoḍha / abhrānta:** non-conceptual and non-erroneous perception.
- FACT: **Apoha:** exclusion theory of meaning; "cow" functions as "not-non-cow".
- FACT: **Svasaṃvedana:** self-awareness of cognition, attacked by Nyāya and central to Buddhist epistemology.
- FACT: **Pramāṇaphala:** resultant cognition, treated by Dignāga as non-different from the pramāṇa-event.

Quick examinable statements

- ANALYSIS: "Ignorance of dependent origination is bondage because it converts process into substance and thereby fuels craving."
- ANALYSIS: "Buddhist momentariness is not chaos but ordered succession."
- ANALYSIS: "The person is neither an illusion in the trivial sense nor an ultimate self; it is a valid conventional designation."
- ANALYSIS: "Śūnyatā denies intrinsic being, not dependent functioning."

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:start -->

RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER

Pañcaskandhas, no-self and liberation

- FACT: The person is conventionally designated upon form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness; none is permanent, autonomous or fit to be owned as “this is mine, this I am”.
- FACT: **Argument:** exhaustive analysis finds only conditioned aggregates; their causal dependence explains continuity without a separate ātman. Liberation is cessation of ignorance, craving and appropriation, not the release of a soul-substance.
- ANALYSIS: **Distinction:** no-self denies intrinsic personal substance, not causal continuity or conventional agency.

Dependent origination, momentariness and emptiness

- FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda radicalises conditioned arising: what depends on causes cannot possess unchanging efficacy. Madhyamaka draws the anti-essentialist conclusion that dependently originated things are empty of svabhāva.
- CAUTION: **Objection -> reply:** emptiness seems self-defeating or nihilistic. Nāgārjuna's reply is that emptiness itself is dependent designation and preserves conventional causation rather than abolishing it.

<!-- restored-2018-2020-doctrine:end -->

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:start -->

CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018–2025 audit)

- ANALYSIS: **Priority:** Primary ownership rises to 13 of 112 parts and occurs in every year.
- FACT: **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored years add the Madhyamaka derivation of śūnyatā from dependent origination, no-self with nirvāṇa, kṣaṇikavāda as a derivative of dependent origination and the pañcaskandha account of personhood/liberation.
- WRONG: **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not identify śūnyatā with non-existence or infer that causal continuity requires a soul; distinguish conventional designation from intrinsic nature.

<!-- expanded-pyq-depth:end -->

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced control of terminology

Technical vocabulary should mark distinctions, not decorate prose. *Anitya* is general impermanence; *kṣaṇikavāda* is the radical scholastic claim of momentariness. *Śūnyatā* denies *svabhāva*, not conventional causation. *Nairātmyavāda* denies permanent selfhood, not the pragmatic designation of persons.

The restored doctrine material also prevents a narrow syllabus reading. Pañcaskandhas, liberation, Buddhist epistemology and the four schools explain how the three headline doctrines actually function.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

Before writing, perform a four-part check:

1. Have I defined the technical term?
2. Have I shown its internal derivation?
3. Have I stated what it does **not** mean?
4. Have I linked it to suffering or liberation?

Use the retained keyword bank and doctrine dossier as the factual checklist for all 13 verified PYQs.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Empty = empty of intrinsic nature.
- No-self = no permanent substance-self.
- Momentary = causally connected momentary events.
- Two truths = conventional operation and ultimate non-intrinsic status.
- Trap: do not call every Buddhist school idealist or nihilist.

Progress: 7 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Buddhist Epistemology and Pragmatic Silence

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - two ways of knowing

PERCEPTION -> unique causal particular, before conceptual construction

INFERENCE -> conceptual and linguistic judgement

Words classify by excluding what the object is not.

In simple words: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept perception and inference as the two fundamental knowledge sources. Perception encounters a unique particular; concepts and words organise experience indirectly.

Term	Easy meaning
<i>Svalakṣaṇa</i>	Unique causal particular
<i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i>	Conceptual general character
<i>Apoha</i>	Meaning through exclusion of alternatives
<i>Pramāṇaphala</i>	Result of valid cognition

Memory line: perception presents the particular; inference and language construct usable classifications.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

9A. BUDDHIST EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRAMĀṆA SCHOOL (Dignāga, Dharmakīrti)

ANALYSIS: Why this matters for UPSC: Buddhist epistemology is not an isolated logic chapter. It translates **nairātmyavāda** and **kṣaṇikavāda** into a theory of knowledge, language and debate.

9A.1 Two-pramāṇa thesis

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti accept only two independent **pramāṇas** (means of valid knowledge): **pratyakṣa** (perception) and **anumāna** (inference).
- FACT: Other candidates — **upamāna** (comparison), **arthāpatti** (postulation), **anupalabdhi** (non-apprehension) and **śabda** (testimony) — are reduced to inference or to perception-plus-inference.

Argument

1. FACT: A pramāṇa must be individuated by the kind of object it reveals.
2. FACT: There are exactly two object-types: **svalakṣaṇa** (unique particular / self-characterised particular) and **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** (general character / constructed universal-aspect).
3. FACT: Perception grasps the **svalakṣaṇa**.
4. FACT: Inference grasps the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa**.

5. FACT: Therefore there are exactly two *pramāṇas*.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: The number of knowledge-sources is fixed by the object-side, not by a mere list of human cognitive habits.
- ANALYSIS: There is no third kind of object beyond the unique causal particular and the constructed general character.

Contrast with Nyāya

Issue	FACT: Buddhist <i>pramāṇa</i> school	FACT: Nyāya
Number of <i>pramāṇas</i>	FACT: Two: perception and inference	FACT: Four: perception, inference, comparison, testimony
Testimony	FACT: reducible to inference from reliable signs / speaker-function	FACT: independent <i>pramāṇa</i>
Universals	FACT: conceptual constructions	FACT: real universals inhering in particulars

9A.2 *Svalakṣaṇa* and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa*

Feature	FACT: <i>Svalakṣaṇa</i>	FACT: <i>Sāmānyalakṣaṇa</i>
Ontological status	FACT: paramārtha-sat (ultimately real)	FACT: saṃvṛti-sat (conventionally real)
Temporal status	FACT: momentary	ANALYSIS: enduring only as a construct
Cognition	FACT: non-conceptual perception	FACT: conceptual inference / judgment
Language	FACT: ineffable as a unique particular	FACT: expressible and shareable
Causal role	FACT: causally efficient	ANALYSIS: causally inert as a universal construct

Distinction

- FACT: The ***svalakṣaṇa*** is unique, momentary, causally efficient, ineffable and non-conceptual.
- FACT: The ***sāmānyalakṣaṇa*** is shareable, expressible and stable only as a conceptual construction.
- ANALYSIS: This is why Buddhist realism about momentary particulars can coexist with nominalism about universals.

9A.3 Perception as *kalpanāpoḍha* and *abhrānta*

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga defines perception as ***kalpanāpoḍha*** (free from conceptual construction).
- FACT: Dharmakīrti adds ***abhrānta*** (non-erroneous), so perception is non-conceptual and non-mistaken.

Why the addition matters

- FACT: Mere vivid presentation is not enough for valid perception.
- FACT: Illusions such as a double moon or the circle produced by a whirling firebrand can be vivid while still mistaken.
- ANALYSIS: Dharmakīrti's addition protects Buddhist epistemology from counting every non-conceptual appearance as valid knowledge.

Fourfold division of perception

Type	FACT: Meaning	ANALYSIS: Philosophical point
indriya-pratyakṣa	FACT: sense perception	ANALYSIS: non-conceptual contact with the particular through sense-faculty
mānasa-pratyakṣa	FACT: mental perception	ANALYSIS: immediate mental awareness following sensory presentation
svasaṃvedana	FACT: self-awareness of cognition	ANALYSIS: cognition manifests itself without a second knower
yogi-pratyakṣa	FACT: yogic perception	ANALYSIS: disciplined direct insight into subtle truths relevant to liberation

- ANALYSIS: **Svasaṃvedana** connects Buddhist epistemology with Yogācāra idealism because cognition is treated as self-revealing; this is why Nyāya attacks it as collapsing object, cognition and knower.

9A.4 Apoha theory of meaning and universals

Statement

- FACT: **Apoha** (exclusion) says a general term does not denote a real universal (**jāti**) inhering in particulars.
- FACT: A word functions through **anya-apoha** (exclusion of the other): “cow” means “not-non-cow”.

Argument

1. FACT: Only unique particulars are ultimately real.
2. FACT: Words and concepts are general.
3. FACT: If generality were real, one would need real universals; but universals are not perceived and produce the Nyāya problems of inherence and location.
4. FACT: Therefore generality must be constructed negatively through exclusion.

Presupposition

- ANALYSIS: Apoha presupposes that a negative / differential function can do the work usually assigned to a positive shared property.

Objection — Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara

- FACT: The exclusion seems circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know what a cow is.
- FACT: A merely negative content seems unable to explain the positive determinate cognition “cow”.
- FACT: It also seems unable to explain the felt similarity among cows.

Reply — Dharmakīrti's line

- FACT: Similarity is grounded not in a shared universal but in a shared causal capacity.
- FACT: Many distinct particulars produce the same effect: the same conceptual judgment and the same successful practical activity.
- FACT: Apoha is a conceptual construct erected upon that causal convergence, not upon a prior grasp of a real universal.
- ANALYSIS: The circularity objection retains residual force; many critics hold that the Buddhist reply does not fully explain positive determination.

9A.5 Arthakriyākāritva as the criterion of the real

Statement

- FACT: **Sat = arthakriyā-samartha**: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect.
- FACT: This criterion ranks the **svalakṣaṇa** as ultimately real and the **sāmānyalakṣaṇa** as conventional.

Argument connecting epistemology to kṣaṇikavāda

1. FACT: To be real is to be causally efficacious.
2. FACT: Causal efficacy must occur either successively or simultaneously.

3. FACT: A permanent entity can do neither coherently: if it produces everything at once, nothing remains for later moments; if it produces successively, it changes; if it needs auxiliary conditions, the decisive efficacy lies in the changing conditions.
4. FACT: Therefore whatever is real is momentary — **yat sat tat kṣaṇikam**.

Exam payoff

- ANALYSIS: This is the clean bridge from pramāṇa theory to ontology: what perception ultimately presents is the momentary causally efficient particular; what inference and language manage is the conventional general construction.

9A.6 Pramāṇa and pramāṇaphala

Statement

- FACT: Dignāga's distinctive thesis is that **pramāṇa** (instrument of knowledge) and **pramāṇaphala** (result of knowledge) are not two ultimately different things.
- FACT: The resultant cognition — the determination of the object and the self-awareness of cognition — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa.

Argument

- FACT: On a momentary and non-substantialist ontology, there is no enduring agent-instrument-result triad.
- FACT: The analysis into **karaṇa** (instrument) and **phala** (result) is a conceptual overlay on one momentary cognitive event.
- ANALYSIS: This shows that Buddhist epistemology is internally driven by **anātman** and **kṣaṇikavāda**, not by free-standing formal logic.

Contrast with Nyāya

Factor	FACT: Nyāya	FACT: Buddhist pramāṇa school
pramātṛ (knower)	FACT: real enduring subject	ANALYSIS: constructed stream, not ultimate self
pramāṇa (instrument)	FACT: distinct means	FACT: non-different from cognition as event
prameya (object)	FACT: independently knowable object	FACT: ultimately svalakṣaṇa; conventionally constructed object
pramiti / pramāṇaphala (result)	FACT: distinct resultant knowledge	FACT: not ultimately separate from pramāṇa

9B. AVYĀKATA / AVYĀKṚTA QUESTIONS — PRAGMATIC SILENCE

9B.1 The undeclared questions

- FACT: **Avyākata** / **avyākṛta** (undeclared / unanswered) questions are questions the Buddha declines to answer in the expected metaphysical format.
- FACT: They include whether the world is eternal or not eternal, finite or infinite; whether the **jīva** (life-principle / self) is the same as or different from the body; and whether the **Tathāgata** exists after death, does not exist, both, or neither.

AVYĀKṚTA CLUSTER

World: eternal? not eternal? finite? infinite?

Self/body: jīva same as body? different from body?

Tathāgata after death: exists? does not exist? both? neither?

9B.2 Why the Buddha declined

Statement

- FACT: The refusal is not a lack of doctrine; it is a disciplined refusal to answer malformed or soteriologically useless questions.

Argument

1. FACT: The questions are **na arthasaṃhita** (not conducive to the goal / not connected with welfare and liberation).
2. FACT: The arrow parable in the **Cūḷamālukya** teaching compares the metaphysical questioner to a man shot with a poisoned arrow who refuses treatment until he learns the archer's caste, name, bow-type and arrow-fletching; he dies before treatment.
3. FACT: The questions rest on a false presupposition: they assume a substantial self or substantial world about which the alternatives can be predicated.
4. ANALYSIS: The structure resembles the loaded question "Have you stopped beating your wife?"; any direct answer concedes the presupposition.
5. FACT: Conditioned cognition cannot settle what is framed beyond the conditions of meaningful experience and liberation-oriented practice.

9B.3 Fire-going-out simile

- FACT: For the Tathāgata-after-death question, early Buddhist teaching uses the fire-going-out simile: when a fire has gone out, it cannot be said to have gone east, west, north or south.
- ANALYSIS: The point is not that a hidden self travels elsewhere; the categories of directional predication no longer apply once the sustaining conditions have ceased.

9B.4 Three readings of the silence

Reading	Claim	Strength	Limit
CAUTION: Agnostic	CAUTION: The Buddha did not know, or the matter is unknowable.	ANALYSIS: Explains non-answering simply.	ANALYSIS: Fits poorly with the strong positive diagnosis of suffering and cessation.
FACT: Pragmatic-therapeutic	FACT: The questions are useless for liberation.	FACT: Best fits the arrow parable's stated reason.	ANALYSIS: May understate the logical problem in the questions.
ANALYSIS: Logical-semantic	ANALYSIS: The questions are malformed because their presupposition of substantial self/world fails.	ANALYSIS: Best fits anātman and dependent origination.	CAUTION: Not always explicitly formulated as a formal semantic theory in early sources.

- CAUTION: The tradition does not settle the issue in a single uncontested interpretation.
- ANALYSIS: For UPSC, combine the second and third readings: the questions are both therapeutically useless and presuppositionally defective.

9B.5 Objection and reply

Objection — realist / metaphysical critic

- FACT: Silence looks like evasion and leaves Buddhism metaphysically indeterminate.

Reply — Buddhist middle way

- FACT: The Buddha's positive teaching is precisely what he declared: Four Noble Truths, dependent origination, path and cessation.
- FACT: The middle way avoids both **śāśvatavāda** (eternalism) and **ucchedavāda** (annihilationism).
- FACT: Answering the avyākṛta questions in any of the four corners would concede the grammar of one of those extremes.
- ANALYSIS: Therefore silence is not emptiness of teaching; it is refusal to let the wrong question control the answer.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced epistemic and pragmatic issues

The two-pramāṇa theory aligns epistemology with momentariness: only the unique causally effective particular is ultimately real, while universals are conceptual. *Apoha* avoids eternal universals by explaining "cow" through exclusion of non-cows, but opponents ask how exclusion works without some positive basis of similarity.

The relation between *pramāṇa* and *pramāṇaphala* reflects a process model of cognition rather than Nyāya's sharply separated instrument and result. This is a high-value cross-school comparison.

The Buddha's silence on undeclared questions is pragmatic, not mere ignorance. The poisoned-arrow reasoning asks whether speculation conduces to cessation. The danger is anti-intellectualism; the defence is disciplined relevance. The silence rejects metaphysical fixation without denying that causal and ethical analysis is possible.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

- For pramāṇa questions, compare Buddhist two-pramāṇa theory with Nyāya's fourfold scheme.
- Define *kalpanāpoḍha* and explain why later Buddhists add non-erroneousness.
- In *apoha*, present the economy gained and the positive-content objection.
- Use pragmatic silence only where relevant; do not turn it into a blanket ban on philosophy.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall

- Two pramāṇas: perception and inference.
- Perception is non-conceptual and non-erroneous.
- Particulars are ultimately causally real; universals are conceptual.
- *Apoha*: exclusion of the other.
- *Avyākata*: questions left undeclared because they do not conduce to liberation.

Progress: 8 / 8 | Philosophy Layered Session | Subtopic: Comparative Synthesis, PYQ Routing and Answer Architecture

LAYER 1 - SIMPLE START

Plain-language visual - the complete Buddhist answer spine

DEPENDENT ORIGINATION
|
IMPERMANENCE / MOMENTARINESS
|
NO PERMANENT SELF
|
CAUSAL CONTINUITY OF KARMA
|
CESSATION OF SUFFERING

In simple words: answer Buddhism as a connected process philosophy. Begin with conditions, derive change and no-self, explain continuity, and end with liberation.

Marks	Minimum structure
10	Define -> derive -> distinction -> significance
15	Doctrine -> example -> objection/reply -> verdict
20	Full causal chain -> school comparison -> dialectic -> assessment

Memory line: no substance is required if conditioned continuity can explain arising, responsibility and cessation.

LAYER 2 - CORE UPSC

9C. PRESUPPOSITION LEDGER

Doctrine	Presupposition	What collapses if denied
FACT: Pratītyasamutpāda	ANALYSIS: Explanation must proceed through conditions rather than a static first substance.	ANALYSIS: The Four Noble Truths lose their causal grammar; suffering becomes fate or mystery.
FACT: Kṣaṇikavāda	ANALYSIS: Whatever is conditioned and causally efficient cannot remain numerically permanent.	ANALYSIS: Buddhist critique of substance weakens; Nyāya-style endurance becomes possible.
FACT: Nairātmyavāda	ANALYSIS: Exhaustive analysis of experience finds aggregates and processes, not an owner behind them.	ANALYSIS: Karma and nirvāṇa must be reinterpreted through an ātman, which Buddhism refuses.
FACT: Arthakriyākāritva	ANALYSIS: Reality is measured by effect-producing capacity, not by inert self-identity.	ANALYSIS: Momentariness loses its strongest logical bridge from epistemology to ontology.
FACT: Apoha	ANALYSIS: Generality can be explained by exclusion and causal convergence without real universals.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya-Mīmāṃsā universals regain explanatory force.
FACT: Two truths	ANALYSIS: Conventional functioning and ultimate analysis answer different questions.	ANALYSIS: Madhyamaka appears either nihilist or secretly realist.
FACT: Śūnyatā	ANALYSIS: Whatever is dependently arisen lacks svabhāva.	ANALYSIS: Dependent origination remains a mere causal theory and does not become anti-essentialist.
FACT: Nirvāṇa	ANALYSIS: Bondage is a conditioned process; cessation is possible without a liberated soul-substance.	ANALYSIS: No-self and liberation appear inconsistent.

9D. PŪRVAPAKṢA–SIDDHĀNTA LEDGER

Objector (named)	Objection	Buddhist reply (school / thinker)	Residual force ANALYSIS:
FACT: Nyāya — Vātsyāyana / Uddyotakara / Udayana	FACT: Recognition, memory and moral desert require an enduring self.	FACT: Sautrāntika/Yogācāra: santāna , sādrśya , flame/river analogies; Yogācāra adds ālaya-vijñāna and bīja .	ANALYSIS: A series may not “own” memories unless something owns the series.
FACT: Nyāya realist	FACT: A permanent substance can act when auxiliaries are present.	FACT: Dharmakīrti line: sahakāri-anapekṣā / kramayaugapadya dilemma; changing conditions do the real work.	ANALYSIS: Nyāya's substance-quality model remains intuitively powerful.
FACT: Kumāṛila Bhaṭṭa	FACT: Self is required for duty, memory and pramāṇa; universals are required for word-meaning.	FACT: Dignāga/Dharmakīrti: momentary cognitions plus apoha explain self and generality conventionally.	ANALYSIS: Apoha's positive-determination problem persists.
FACT: Uddyotakara	FACT: Apoha is circular: to exclude non-cows one must already know cow.	FACT: Dharmakīrti: exclusion is grounded in causal convergence and successful activity, not a prior universal.	ANALYSIS: The circularity charge is not fully dissolved for many critics.
FACT: Śaṃkara / Advaita	FACT: Momentariness makes bondage/liberation and unity of knower unintelligible; śūnyatā presupposes witnessing consciousness.	FACT: Madhyamaka/Yogācāra replies through two truths and self-revealing cognition without ātman.	ANALYSIS: Unity of experience remains the strongest Advaitic pressure point.
FACT: Nyāya / modern realist	FACT: Catuskoṭi denial is self-contradictory or says nothing.	FACT: Nāgārjuna: non-implicative negation; empty words cure empty reification; no independent thesis.	ANALYSIS: Prāsaṅgika vs Svātantrika dispute shows internal unease.
FACT: Puggalavāda / Vātsīputrīya foil	FACT: A person neither identical with nor different from skandhas is needed for continuity.	FACT: Mainstream Buddhism: this risks reintroducing a disguised self; continuity is conventional designation on aggregates.	ANALYSIS: The pressure to preserve agency explains why the foil arose.
FACT: Cārvāka materialist	FACT: Reject self beyond body and deny post-mortem continuity.	FACT: Buddhism rejects permanent self but preserves karmic causal continuity beyond gross-body reduction.	ANALYSIS: Requires accepting causal continuity not directly reducible to perception.

9E. INTER-SCHOOL POSITIONING

School	Pramāṇas	Ontology of self	Permanence / change	Causation	Universals	Scripture	Liberation
FACT: Buddhism	FACT: Dignāga -Dharmakīrti: two, perception and inference	FACT: no permanent ātman; person is aggregate / stream	FACT: conditioned reals are momentary	FACT: dependent origination	FACT: apoha; no real jāti	FACT: Buddha-word valued, but not Vedic infallibility	FACT: cessation of ignorance, craving and duḥkha-process
FACT: Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika	FACT: usually four in classical Nyāya	FACT: enduring self-substance	FACT: substances endure through changing qualities	FACT: ārambhavāda-style production and theistic order in later Nyāya	FACT: real universals	FACT: testimony as pramāṇa, Veda accepted	FACT: true knowledge of self and categories, cessation of suffering
FACT: Sāṃkhya-Yoga	FACT: perception, inference and reliable testimony	FACT: many puruṣas	FACT: puruṣa permanent; prakṛti transforms	FACT: satkāryavāda / pariṇāma	ANALYSIS: less central than tattva structure	FACT: scripture accepted with reasoning	FACT: kaivalya, isolation of puruṣa from prakṛti
FACT: Jainism	FACT: multiple pramāṇa/naya approaches	FACT: real jīva, intrinsically conscious	FACT: substance persists with changing modes	FACT: anekāntavāda and pariṇāmic change	FACT: real common features within many-sided realism	FACT: Jaina āgama authority	FACT: release of jīva from karmic matter
FACT: Mīmāṃsā	FACT: expands pramāṇas; Kumārila accepts several including arthāpatti and anupalabdhi	FACT: enduring self as agent/enjoyer	FACT: enduring subject and real ritual order	FACT: ritual efficacy and apūrva	FACT: real universals	FACT: Veda intrinsically authoritative	FACT: often framed through dharma and cessation of obstacles, varies by sub-school
FACT: Cārvāka	FACT: perception alone	FACT: self identified with body / consciousness as bodily product	FACT: material elements persist; no rebirth-continuity	FACT: material causation only	ANALYSIS: rejects metaphysical universals beyond perception	FACT: rejects Veda	FACT: no mokṣa beyond worldly well-being
FACT: Advaita Vedānta	FACT: six in developed Advaita	FACT: ātman = Brahman, self-luminous	FACT: Brahman permanent; world ultimately mithyā	FACT: vivarta / appearance	ANALYSIS: empirical universals within māyā	FACT: Upaniṣadic revelation central	FACT: knowledge of Brahman

9E.1 Buddhism vs Jainism — high-yield distinction

- FACT: Both are non-Vedic śramaṇa traditions and both reject a creator God as necessary for liberation.
- FACT: Jainism affirms **anekāntavāda** (many-sidedness): a substance can be permanent in substance and changing in modes.
- FACT: Buddhism denies substance: what looks like persistence is a conditioned series without an underlying dravya.
- FACT: The Jaina **jīva** is real and omniscient by nature when freed from karmic obstruction; the Buddhist self is a construct designated on skandhas.
- ANALYSIS: Trap to avoid: do not say both deny the soul. Buddhism denies ātman; Jainism strongly affirms jīva.

9E.2 Buddhism vs Advaita — avoid the “crypto-Advaita” trap

- FACT: Both deny that ordinary world-experience is ultimately real in the naive realist sense.
- FACT: Advaita's ultimate is positive, self-luminous **Brahman / ātman**.

- FACT: Madhyamaka **śūnyatā** is absence of **svabhāva**, not a hidden substrate.
- FACT: Advaita sublates world into Brahman; Madhyamaka refuses to replace empty phenomena with a metaphysical ground.
- ANALYSIS: Trap to refute: "Buddhist emptiness is just Advaita Brahman under another name." The Buddhist case is anti-substantialist; Advaita is absolute-substantialist.

9F. CONTROLLED WESTERN COMPARISON

Western comparison	Point of contact	Disanalogy
FACT: Hume's bundle theory vs anātman	FACT: Both deny a substantial self on broadly empiricist grounds.	ANALYSIS: Hume has no karmic continuity, no nirvāṇa-soteriology and treats self as imagination's fiction; Buddhism has a morally weighted causal series.
FACT: Heraclitus' flux vs kṣaṇikavāda	FACT: Both stress universal change.	ANALYSIS: Heraclitus retains logos as ordering principle; Buddhist momentariness is tied to dependent origination and causal efficacy.
FACT: Whitehead's process thought vs momentary dharmas	FACT: Both treat reality as event/process rather than inert substance.	ANALYSIS: Whitehead's metaphysical scheme is not the Buddhist no-self path and has no apoha or nirvāṇa framework.
FACT: Nāgārjuna's catuṣkoṭi vs Kant's antinomies	FACT: Both show reason generating opposed metaphysical conclusions.	ANALYSIS: Kant preserves the phenomenal object and limits categories; Nāgārjuna targets svabhāva itself through emptiness.
FACT: Wittgenstein's therapeutic philosophy vs Buddha's silence	FACT: Both dissolve misleading questions rather than answer them on their own terms.	ANALYSIS: The Buddha's therapy is soteriological and rooted in duḥkha, karma and liberation.
FACT: Ockham's nominalism vs apoha	FACT: Both deny real universals.	ANALYSIS: Apoha's negative-exclusion mechanism and karmic-epistemic background have no exact Ockhamite counterpart; Ockham retains enduring individuals.

- **ANALYSIS: Rubric:** Western parallels are illustrative only; they must never replace the Indian argument and belong in at most one or two lines after the Buddhist case is complete.

9G. DIRECTIVE DECODER

Directive	What the examiner is testing	Structural move for a Buddhism answer	Closing verdict
Discuss	FACT: balanced exposition of doctrine and significance	ANALYSIS: define -> explain argument -> add school nuance -> conclude	ANALYSIS: "Thus the doctrine is central because..."
Examine	FACT: internal logic and assumptions	ANALYSIS: state thesis -> reconstruct reasoning -> expose presupposition	ANALYSIS: "It stands if its presupposition about ... is accepted."
Critically examine	FACT: doctrine plus objections/replies	ANALYSIS: doctrine -> named objection -> Buddhist reply -> residual force	ANALYSIS: "Strong as soteriology, debated as metaphysics."
Analyse	FACT: break doctrine into components	ANALYSIS: divide into causation, self, moment, liberation, epistemology	ANALYSIS: "The components converge on anti-substantialism."
Evaluate	FACT: final judgment on adequacy	ANALYSIS: strengths -> weaknesses -> contested point -> verdict	ANALYSIS: "Adequate for ..., weaker against ..."
Compare	FACT: similarity and difference across schools	ANALYSIS: use a table; then add one decisive contrast	ANALYSIS: "Similarity is formal; difference is doctrinal."
Distinguish	FACT: precise separation of close terms	ANALYSIS: two-column definitions, criteria and example	ANALYSIS: "Confusing them causes the standard UPSC trap."
Elucidate	FACT: clarify with examples	ANALYSIS: statement -> example -> doctrinal consequence	ANALYSIS: "The example shows the doctrine's exact sense."
Comment	FACT: interpret a quotation / claim	ANALYSIS: unpack claim -> support -> qualify -> conclude	ANALYSIS: "The claim is acceptable if read as ... not as ..."
Bring out	FACT: make an implicit relation explicit	ANALYSIS: show link, e.g. <i>pratītyasamutpāda</i> -> <i>kṣaṇikavāda</i> -> <i>nairātmya</i>	ANALYSIS: "The relation is logical, not merely historical."
Do you agree?	FACT: reasoned position	ANALYSIS: partial agreement -> objection -> defended verdict	ANALYSIS: "I agree in the conventional/ultimate sense specified above."

9H. GRADED VERDICT ON BUDDHISM

9H.1 What is strong

- FACT: Buddhism gives a powerful process-based account of suffering, causation and liberation through **pratītyasamutpāda**.
- FACT: It avoids both eternalism and annihilationism by using causal continuity without an eternal self.
- FACT: *Kṣaṇikavāda* is supported by a sharp causal-efficacy argument, especially in Dharmakīrti's *pramāṇa* framework.
- FACT: *Madhyamaka*'s two truths allow it to deny intrinsic nature without abolishing ordinary practice.

9H.2 What is weak

- ANALYSIS: The denial of a persisting subject makes memory, recognition and moral desert philosophically difficult.
- ANALYSIS: *Apoha* explains universals economically but struggles to account for positive determinate cognition.
- ANALYSIS: *Catuṣkoṭi* and "no thesis" replies can look self-referentially unstable unless the non-implicative-negation nuance is clearly stated.

9H.3 What is genuinely contested

- CAUTION: Whether **svasaṃvedana** proves self-awareness or merely reifies cognition is debated between Buddhist epistemologists and *Nyāya*.

- CAUTION: Whether Madhyamaka's empty statements avoid self-refutation is debated both internally and by opponents.
- CAUTION: Whether a causal series is sufficient for moral responsibility without an owner remains the core cross-school dispute.

9H.4 Ready one-line verdicts

- ANALYSIS: **10 marks:** Buddhism replaces substance with conditioned process: this makes suffering removable, but raises the problem of continuity without self.
- ANALYSIS: **15 marks:** Its doctrines of dependent origination, momentariness and no-self form a coherent anti-substantialist system, though Nyāya and Vedānta press hard on memory, agency and liberation.
- ANALYSIS: **20 marks:** Buddhism is strongest as a therapeutic and causal philosophy of liberation; its deepest unresolved issue is whether causal continuity and two truths can fully replace the metaphysical work done by self, substance and universals in rival systems.

10. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 13 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2018	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.
2018	Q6(b)	15 marks	Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.
2019	Q5(b)	10 marks	How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.
2019	Q7(c)	15 marks	What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?
2020	Q6(a)	20 marks	How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.
2020	Q7(b)	15 marks	How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?
2021	Q5(d)	10 marks	Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.
2021	Q7(b)	15 marks	If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.
2022	Q6(a)	20 marks	How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.
2022	Q7(b)	15 marks	Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).
2023	Q8(a)	20 marks	"Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.
2024	Q6(b)	15 marks	How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda? Answer with arguments.
2025	Q8(c)	15 marks	Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

11. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks)

11.1 For a 10-marker

Define the doctrine in one line.

State the core argument in 3–4 crisp steps.

Add one distinction (e.g. pudgala- vs dharma-nairātmya; realism vs emptiness).

Close with one line of significance.

11.2 For a 15-marker

Intro: locate the issue in Buddhist soteriology.

Body A: doctrine stated precisely.

Body B: argument with one example.

Body C: objection and Buddhist reply.

Conclusion: show why the doctrine matters for duḥkha / nirvāṇa.

11.3 For a 20-marker

Frame: connect the question to the Four Noble Truths.

Exposition: full doctrine with technical vocabulary.

Analysis: derive the linked Buddhist claim (e.g. momentariness from dependent origination).

Debate: contrast two schools or answer a major objection.

Verdict: give a balanced philosophical assessment.

12. LINK-OUTS

- Nyaya-Vaisesika.md — contrast on self, causation, pramāṇa and God.
- Carvaka.md — contrast on self and rejection of transcendence.
- Jainism.md — compare continuity-through-change with Buddhist momentariness.
- ../_themes/Causation-across-schools.md — pratītyasamutpāda vs satkāryavāda vs ārambhavāda.
- ../_themes/Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md — anātman vs ātman accounts.
- ../_PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md — year-wise Indian Philosophy routing.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Proofs-for-God.md — cross-paper God debate.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Religion-without-God.md — Buddhism as a non-theistic religion.
- ../paper-2/philosophy-of-religion/Soul-Immortality-Rebirth.md — rebirth without immortal soul.

SOURCES

- *Majjhima Nikāya* and related early Buddhist formulations of dependent origination, used in substance where directly phrased.
- Nāgārjuna, *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, especially the standard identification in substance of dependent origination and emptiness.
- Chatterjee & Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. I and II, where relevant to Buddhist schools.
- Standard expositions of *Milinda-pañha* for the chariot analogy, paraphrased where exact wording is uncertain.
- FACT: Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, standard pramāṇa-school doctrines of perception, inference, apoha and pramāṇaphala, paraphrased without verse-number claims.
- FACT: Early Buddhist discussions of the avyākata / avyākṛta questions and the Cūḷamālukya arrow parable, used in substance without invented citation numbering.
- FACT: Nāgārjuna, *Vigrahavyāvartanī*, for the no-thesis / self-referential defence, used in substance without verse-number claims.

CURRENT LINKAGE - BUDDHIST HERITAGE AS CULTURAL DIPLOMACY

FACT: Official fact: The High Commission of India in Colombo reported that India sent the Devnimori Buddha relics from Gujarat to the Gangaramaya Temple, Colombo, for public exposition from **4 to 10 February 2026**. The official release described the initiative as cultural and spiritual engagement with Sri Lanka through shared Buddhist heritage.

ANALYSIS: Philosophy Optional use: This event does not prove any Buddhist doctrine. Use it only as a contemporary introduction or conclusion showing how a philosophical-religious tradition also functions as a civilizational language in diplomacy. Doctrinal answers must remain grounded in pratityasamutpada, momentariness, no-self, the two truths, compassion, and the relevant school.

Source trail used for this package

- FACT: Repository owner: paper-1/indian/Buddhism.md.
- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 149-194: dependent origination, transience, no-self, and the four schools.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 67-81: early Buddhism, twelve links, momentariness, realist schools, and nirvana.
- FACT: Official High Commission of India, Colombo release on the Devnimori relic exposition, rechecked 18 August 2026.

LAYER 3 - ADVANCED

Advanced synthesis

Buddhism's greatest strength is the integration of metaphysics and therapy. Dependent origination explains why suffering arises and how it can cease; momentariness and no-self prevent reification; the schools then debate how much reality, consciousness or emptiness the process requires.

Its central philosophical risk is that causal continuity may not fully replace first-person unity, recognition and moral ownership. Madhyamaka adds a second risk: anti-essentialist language can look self-refuting unless the two truths and emptiness of emptiness are stated clearly.

The defensible verdict is neither "Buddhism denies reality" nor "Buddhism is modern science." It is a rigorous anti-substantialist and soteriological process philosophy whose internal variants range from realism to idealist analysis and radical emptiness.

LINK: Current conceptual anchor: the February 2026 Devnimori relic exposition in Colombo, officially documented by the High Commission of India, illustrates Buddhist heritage as cultural diplomacy. It is contextual evidence only, never proof of doctrine.

LAYER 4 - EXAM APPLICATION

Exam route

The complete corpus contains **13 primary-owned questions from 2018-2025**:

- Dependent origination and emptiness: 2018.
- Yogācāra external-world critique: 2019.
- Momentariness derivation: 2019 and 2020.
- No-self, aggregates and nirvāṇa: 2018, 2020, 2021 and 2025.
- Memory and karma under momentariness: 2021 and 2022.
- Triratna and no-self: 2022.
- Soteriology through dependent origination: 2023.
- Realism versus emptiness: 2024.

The retained routing table, directive decoder and marks-wise frameworks below should be used before attempting the full solved practice.

LAYER 5 - RAPID REVISION

Rapid recall - final master matrix

Prompt	Recall spine
Causation	conditioned arising and cessation
Reality	causal efficacy; momentary particulars
Person	five aggregates and causal designation
Continuity	<i>santāna</i> , seeds and store-consciousness
Schools	direct realism -> inferred realism -> cognition-only -> emptiness
Language	<i>apoha</i>
Liberation	cessation of the causes of suffering
Verdict	process without substance; continuity with an ownership burden

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: How do the Madhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratityasamutpada to establish their doctrine of Sunyata? Discuss.

Model solution

For Madhyamika, **pratityasamutpada** means that every phenomenon arises only through causes, conditions, conceptual designation, and relations. A thing possessing **svabhava**, or self-existent own-nature, would be independent, unproduced and incapable of alteration. Dependently originated things cannot satisfy that condition.

dependent arising
 ↓
 absence of independent own-nature
 ↓
 emptiness of svabhava
 ↓
 conventional, relational existence

Therefore Nagarjuna treats dependent origination and **sunyata** as two descriptions of the same fact. Emptiness does not mean non-existence. A chariot, person or flame works conventionally, but none exists as a self-grounded substance apart from components and conditions.

The doctrine is protected from nihilism by the **two truths**. At the level of *samvrti-satya*, causation, language, karma and compassion operate. At the level of *paramartha-satya*, no entity survives analysis as intrinsically existent. Sunyata is itself empty and must not be reified into an Absolute.

Verdict: Madhyamika moves from causal dependence to ontological anti-essentialism, not from dependence to sheer nothingness.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact derivation, defines svabhava, uses the two truths, and answers the standard nihilism objection within a compact 10-mark structure.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2018 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairatmyavada and the doctrine of Nirvana simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Model solution

Nairatmyavada denies a permanent, unchanging owner behind the five skandhas. **Nirvana** is the cessation of ignorance, craving and the causal process that reproduces suffering. The two are consistent if liberation is understood as transformation and cessation within a causal stream, not as the release of an eternal soul.

The person is conventionally designated upon rupa, vedana, samjna, samskara and vijñana. Ignorance imputes an enduring "I" to this changing complex; craving and appropriation follow from that imputation.

self-grasping -> craving -> clinging -> becoming -> suffering
insight into no-self -> non-grasping -> cessation -> nirvana

An opponent may argue that without a self there is nobody who suffers, practises or becomes liberated. Buddhism replies through **santana**, causal continuity. The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Conventional agency remains adequate for discipline and responsibility.

Theravada accounts commonly stress cessation of greed, hatred and delusion; Mahayana adds that samsara and nirvana are not two self-existent realms, because both are empty of svabhava. Neither account requires a substantial atman.

Verdict: The denial of a permanent self is not an obstacle to nirvana; it is the cognitive condition for ending the grasping that sustains bondage. The residual pressure concerns whether an ownerless stream fully explains first-person liberation.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes self from causal continuity, connects no-self to suffering, adds school nuance, and gives a balanced critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: How do the Yogacara Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Model solution

Yogacara advances **vijnaptimatratā**: what is given in experience is cognition or representation, not an independently established external object. Dream experience shows that a structured subject-object world can appear without corresponding external things. The object in waking cognition is likewise inseparable from the form in which consciousness presents it.

Yogacara also argues that a material object cannot coherently be identified as one indivisible atom, an aggregate of atoms, or a whole distinct from its parts. Further, a momentary external object would have ceased before the cognition allegedly caused by it became available.

The positive account uses **alaya-vijñana**, the store-consciousness carrying karmic seeds. Seeds mature into coordinated experiences, explaining apparent stability and intersubjective regularity.

Nature	Meaning
Parikalpita	imagined subject-object duality
Paratantra	dependently arisen flow of cognition
Parinippanna	perfected realization of the absence of duality

Verdict: Yogacara denies external objects as independently established causes of experience, but not the ordered causal flow of consciousness. Its weakness is explaining shared experience without covertly rebuilding an external world.

Why this earns marks: It combines the dream and atom arguments with alaya-vijñana and tri-svabhava rather than merely asserting "mind-only."

Solved PYQ 4 - 2019 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: What is Pratityasamutpada? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada is the law that conditioned phenomena arise when their conditions arise and cease when those conditions cease. Its existential expression is the twelve-link chain from avidya to jara-marana; its general philosophical form is conditional dependence.

Momentariness follows because a conditioned thing cannot remain unchanged while its conditioning complex changes. Buddhist logicians reinforce this through **arthakriyakaritva**, causal efficacy:

1. The real is what performs a causal function.
2. A wholly permanent thing would possess the same causal capacity at every time.
3. It should therefore produce its effect always or never.
4. If it acts only with auxiliaries, the changed causal situation, not an unchanged substance, explains the effect.
5. Real causal operation belongs to moment-specific events.
6. Hence, *yat sat tat ksanikam* - whatever is real is momentary.

The apparent endurance of a flame, person or seed is explained as **santana**, a succession of causally connected but numerically distinct moments.

Nyaya objects that enduring substances act when helper-conditions arrive and that memory and recognition require identity. Buddhism replies that each causal phase inherits capacities from its predecessor and recognition tracks similarity within a stream. Yet ownership of memory remains a serious pressure point.

Verdict: Dependent origination supplies impermanence; causal efficacy turns it into the stricter doctrine of momentariness.

Why this earns marks: It separates the early causal doctrine from the later logical proof, handles the auxiliary-condition objection, and concludes critically.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2020 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: How is Ksanikavada a logical derivative of Pratityasamutpada in Buddhism? Explain.

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada states that no conditioned event is self-grounded: "this being, that arises; with the cessation of this, that ceases." Ksanikavada radicalizes this impermanence into the claim that every causally real entity exists only for a moment.

The derivation has three layers. First, an independently permanent substance would not need conditions. Since phenomena arise and cease with conditions, they lack unchanging substantial existence. Second, a cause that produces an effect has exercised a determinate capacity; the causal phase after production cannot be strictly identical to the phase before it. Third, the arthakriya dilemma states:

If permanent X causes E:
+- simultaneously -> X should produce all effects at once
+- successively -> X has different powers at different times
and is therefore not wholly unchanged

Nyaya invokes **sahakarīn**, auxiliary conditions. The Buddhist asks whether X already has the relevant power. If yes, delay is unexplained; if no, the new causal complex bears the explanatory work. Reality thus belongs to momentary causal particulars.

Continuity is preserved as **santana**, a causal succession. This supports memory, karma and rebirth without a permanent bearer, although critics argue that resemblance and causation do not fully explain ownership.

Madhyamika adds that momentary dharmas must not themselves be reified. If they arise dependently, they too are empty of svabhava.

Verdict: Ksanikavada is a logical derivative when pratityasamutpada is joined to causal efficacy. Conditionality establishes impermanence; arthakriya establishes moment-specific reality.

Why this earns marks: It provides a layered derivation, formal dilemma, Nyaya objection and reply, santana, and Madhyamika refinement appropriate to a 20-marker.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2020 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pancaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Model solution

Buddhism analyses the person into five aggregates: **rupa** (form), **vedana** (feeling), **samjna** (recognition), **samskara** (formations), and **vijnana** (consciousness). None is permanent, fully controllable or an adequate self; nor is a self found outside or as owner of them.

The *Milindapanha* chariot analogy clarifies the person's status. "Chariot" designates an organized set of parts; likewise "person" is a conventional designation for an aggregate-stream. This avoids both eternalism and annihilationism: no immutable soul exists, yet a causally continuous process remains.

Liberation is **nirvana**, the cessation of avidya, craving, clinging and production of suffering. The Eightfold Path transforms the stream through morality, concentration and wisdom. The person who begins and the liberated person are causally continuous without being one enduring substance.

An objection says practice is pointless if no one receives its result. The reply is that moral succession requires causal continuity, not numerical identity.

Verdict: Pancaskandha analysis removes the imagined owner; liberation removes the causes of bondage within the conventional continuum.

Why this earns marks: It names all five skandhas, uses the chariot, defines liberation positively, and answers the agency objection.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2021 Q5(d), 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between pudgala-nairatmyavada and dharma-nairatmyavada with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Model solution

Doctrine	What it denies	Primary scope	Typical association
Pudgala-nairatmya	permanent personal self	person composed of five skandhas	shared broadly across Buddhism
Dharma-nairatmya	intrinsic self-nature of dharmas	elements constituting person and world	developed emphatically in Mahayana

Pudgala-nairatmya says no owner exists apart from the aggregates. The person is a conventional designation upon a causal stream. Some Abhidharma realists nevertheless treat the constituent dharmas as ultimately real.

Dharma-nairatmya extends the critique: even dharmas do not possess independent svabhava. Madhyamika grounds this in dependent origination; Yogacara connects it with absence of subject-object duality.

The second doctrine prevents analysis of the person from turning dharmas into metaphysical atoms. Together they remove selfhood at personal and elemental levels.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact object of denial, identifies the school-level development, and explains why the second doctrine is necessary.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2021 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Momentariness denies an enduring mental subject, apparently making memory impossible: the experiencer has perished before remembering occurs. Buddhism responds with **santana**, a causal continuum. An experience leaves a disposition in the next moment; transmission produces a later memory.

Sautrantika speaks of causal seeds or traces. Yogacara uses **alaya-vijnana**, whose bija preserve karmic and mnemonic potential. Personal identity is conventional continuity based on causal connection, bodily organization, resemblance and inherited dispositions:

experience -> impression -> transmitted seed -> occasioning condition -> memory

The later rememberer is neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than the earlier experiencer. Strict identity would reintroduce an atman; total difference would destroy responsibility.

Nyaya objects that memory has the form "I experienced this," requiring one subject to connect the cognitions. Similarity may explain resemblance but not ownership. Buddhism replies that ownership is itself constructed within a causally integrated stream.

Verdict: Buddhist models explain informational transmission economically, but remain vulnerable if first-person appropriation is treated as irreducible.

Why this earns marks: It addresses both memory and identity, names school-specific mechanisms, and gives the strongest Nyaya objection and reply.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2022 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? How do Buddhists respond to objections raised by opponents? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Karma appears to require a persisting agent who acts and later receives the fruit. Ksanikavada denies such an enduring subject. Buddhism reconciles them by replacing substance-identity with causal continuity.

intention -> karmic impression -> causal transmission -> maturation -> fruit

Sautrantika uses seed-like causal potency; Yogacara locates bija in alaya-vijnana; Abhidharma traditions employ causal relations within the dharma-series. All reject an unchanging owner.

Nyaya and Mimamsa raise three objections:

1. **Krtanasa:** the doer's destruction seems to make the deed lost.
2. **Akratabhyagama:** a later different moment seems to receive an unperformed act's fruit.
3. Praise, blame and recognition seem to require one subject.

Buddhism replies that these objections assume only absolute identity or absolute difference. A causally continuous stream is sufficiently connected for responsibility. A child and adult differ profoundly, yet ordinary morality treats them as one practical continuum.

The pressure remains: causal inheritance explains why B follows A, but does it explain why the fruit is *mine*? Alaya-vijnana improves continuity but may resemble a quasi-self. Madhyamika avoids reifying even the stream and treats karma as conventionally valid.

Verdict: Karma and momentariness are compatible if moral responsibility needs causal and conventional identity rather than a numerically identical substance.

Why this earns marks: It states the compatibility mechanism, names classical objections, differentiates schools, and reaches a genuinely critical verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2022 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with No-soul.

Model solution

The **Triratna** are Buddha, Dhamma and Sangha. Buddha is the awakened teacher and exemplar; Dhamma is truth and path; Sangha is the community preserving and embodying the path.

Buddha discovers and teaches Dhamma
Dhamma makes awakening intelligible
Sangha preserves and practises Dhamma
Sangha produces further exemplars

No-soul does not contradict refuge in Buddha because Buddha is not an eternal atman or creator. Nor does it contradict Sangha, a conventional community of causal persons. Dhamma explicitly includes insight into anatta.

The objection is that refuge and discipline require stable agents and authorities. Buddhism answers through two levels: conventionally, teachers and practitioners exist; ultimately, none possesses independent selfhood.

Verdict: Triratna and no-self are consistent when refuge is practical orientation rather than submission of one immortal soul to another.

Why this earns marks: It defines each jewel, shows their internal relation, and resolves the issue through conventional and ultimate levels.

Solved PYQ 11 - 2023 Q8(a), 20 marks

Question: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present Buddhist soteriology in this light.

Model solution

Buddhist soteriology treats suffering as a dependently sustained process. **Avidya** misconstrues impermanent, conditioned and selfless phenomena as permanent, satisfactory and owned by a self. This error generates craving and clinging.

avidya -> samskara -> vijnana -> nama-rupa -> sadayatana
-> sparsa -> vedana -> trsna -> upadana -> bhava -> jati
-> jara-marana

Knowledge reverses the chain's practical force. Feeling need not become craving; craving need not become clinging. Insight into impermanence and no-self removes appropriation, while sila and samadhi weaken habits reproducing ignorance.

Division	Path factors	Function
Prajna	right view, right resolve	sees dependence and no-self
Sila	speech, action, livelihood	stops fresh harmful conditioning
Samadhi	effort, mindfulness, concentration	transforms attention and craving

Abhidharma analyses the causal stream into dharmas. Yogacara purifies seeds in consciousness. Madhyamika sees dependent phenomena as empty, preventing attachment even to doctrine and nirvana.

Mere verbal knowledge cannot liberate; wisdom must become non-grasping perception supported by conduct and meditation.

Verdict: Ignorance is suffering because it constructs appropriation in the causal chain. Knowledge is cessation when embodied as a path that removes renewed craving's conditions.

Why this earns marks: It integrates the quotation, twelve links, Eightfold Path, school nuance, and the distinction between intellectual and transformative knowledge.

Solved PYQ 12 - 2024 Q6(b), 15 marks

Question: How do two schools arrive at "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratityasamutpada?

Model solution

The opposition arises because schools ask different questions of dependent origination.

Madhyamika: If a thing arises dependently, it lacks svabhava. What lacks self-nature is **sunya**. "Everything is void" means no dharma is intrinsically existent; conventional causation remains valid.

Vaibhasika and Sautrantika: Causal interaction shows conditioned dharmas are real. Vaibhasika holds external dharmas directly perceived; Sautrantika infers external momentary particulars from representations. "Everything is real" means causally efficacious dharmas are not illusions, though impermanent.

Shared premise	Realist inference	Madhyamika inference
things arise through conditions	causal efficacy establishes conditioned reality	dependence disproves intrinsic nature
no permanent substance	momentary dharmas are real	even momentary dharmas are empty
ordinary practice works	realism explains causal order	convention explains causal order

The conclusions conflict only if "real" and "void" are univocal. Realists affirm causal reality; Madhyamika denies ultimate self-existence.

Verdict: One doctrine supports realism about causal functioning and emptiness about self-nature. The real dispute is whether momentary dharmas remain ultimately real.

Why this earns marks: It identifies the schools, distinguishes two senses of reality, and dissolves superficial contradiction without erasing genuine disagreement.

Solved PYQ 13 - 2025 Q8(c), 15 marks

Question: Is Buddhist Nirvana in consonance with Ksanikavada and Nairatmyavada? Critically discuss.

Model solution

Nirvana is consonant with momentariness and no-self if understood as cessation of suffering's causes, not an eternal soul entering a permanent state. Ksanikavada shows conditioned processes can cease; nairatmyavada shows liberation needs no immutable owner.

conditioned arising of suffering
↓ insight and path
cessation of its causes
↓
nirvana

An opponent argues that if nirvana is real and permanent, it contradicts momentariness; if momentary, it cannot be final; and without a self, nobody attains it. Buddhism replies that ksanikavada applies to conditioned entities. Nirvana is **asamskrta**, unconditioned, or more cautiously the cessation of the conditioned process. No subject-substance is required for cessation.

Madhyamika refuses to reify nirvana. Samsara and nirvana are empty of svabhava; their distinction concerns ignorance and insight, not two substances.

Verdict: The doctrines are consonant within process ontology. Tension appears only if nirvana is interpreted as an eternal positive entity or personal attainment is assumed to require a substantial self.

Why this earns marks: It answers both compatibility conditions, distinguishes conditioned from unconditioned, adds Madhyamika nuance, and identifies the exact source of possible inconsistency.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	The general formula of pratityasamutpada states that: A. conditioned events arise and cease with conditions B. every effect pre-exists materially in its cause C. an eternal self coordinates change D. God initiates the causal series	A	Dependent origination is conditional arising and cessation.
2	In the twelve-link chain, craving is followed by: A. feeling B. clinging C. contact D. consciousness	B	Trsna conditions upadana.
3	The Buddhist middle way avoids: A. realism and idealism B. perception and inference C. eternalism and annihilationism D. ethics and meditation	C	Dependent process is neither immutable substance nor sheer nullity.
4	Arthakriyakaritva means: A. universal predicability B. linguistic definition C. permanent identity D. capacity for causal efficacy	D	Buddhist logicians connect reality with effect-producing capacity.
5	The simultaneity horn says a permanent cause would: A. produce all effects at once B. possess no quality C. become universal D. require perception only	A	Complete unchanged power gives no reason for delayed production.
6	Santana means: A. permanent substance B. causal continuum C. creator consciousness D. universal inherence	B	It explains continuity without numerical identity.
7	The chariot analogy establishes: A. direct realism B. atomism C. conventional personhood without substantial self D. divine causation	C	Person is designated upon organized aggregates.
8	Which is not a skandha? A. rupa B. vedana C. vijnana D. atman	D	Atman is what aggregate analysis does not find.
9	Pudgala-nairatmya denies: A. enduring personal self B. conventional persons C. causal relations D. liberation	A	It denies substance-self, not conventional designation.
10	Dharma-nairatmya is strongest in: A. materialism B. Mahayana C. Nyaya D. Mimamsa	B	Mahayana extends no-self to dharmas.
11	Vaibhasika is: A. absolute idealism B. nihilism C. direct realism D. Advaita	C	External dharmas are directly perceived.
12	Sautrantika knows external objects through: A. revelation B. yogic intuition C. non-cognition D. inference from representations	D	It is inferential or representational realism.
13	Yogacara's store-consciousness is: A. alaya-vijnana B. mano-vijnana C. kevala-jnana D. saksi	A	It carries seeds and dispositions.
14	Imagined subject-object duality is: A. paratantra B. parikalpita C. parinispanna D. paramartha	B	Parikalpita is constructed nature.
15	Sunyata means: A. absolute non-being B. hidden substance C. absence of intrinsic nature D. denial of conventional causation	C	Emptiness is anti-essentialism.
16	The two truths are: A. perception and inference B. being and non-being C. self and matter D. conventional and ultimate	D	Samvrti and paramartha prevent nihilism and reification.
17	Catuskoti examines: A. is, is not, both, neither B. one, many, universal, particular C. cause, effect, substance, quality D. four pramanas	A	The tetrallemma tests reified alternatives.
18	Emptiness of emptiness prevents: A. causation B. reification of sunyata C. conduct D. speech	B	Sunyata is not a new Absolute.
19	Dignaga-Dharmakirti admit: A. one pramana B. three C. two D. six	C	Perception and inference are fundamental.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
20	Svalaksana is: A. universal B. self C. verbal construction D. unique causal particular	D	It is the ultimate object of non-conceptual perception.
21	Apoha explains meaning by: A. exclusion of the other B. eternal universals C. divine convention D. substance-contact	A	"Cow" works by excluding non-cows.
22	Memory is explained through: A. eternal witness B. causal transmission in a stream C. denial of memory D. body alone	B	Santana, seeds and alaya transmit dispositions.
23	Karma avoids strict identity and difference through: A. inference B. creator C. causal continuity D. permanent moral self	C	The recipient belongs to the same stream.
24	Nirvana with no-self is: A. ego immortality B. atman migration C. permanent-person destruction D. cessation without eternal owner	D	Liberation is cessation within process ontology.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Correct sequence: A. vedana -> trsna -> upadana -> bhava B. trsna -> vedana -> bhava -> sparsa C. upadana -> sparsa -> vedana -> avidya D. bhava -> avidya -> vijnana -> vedana	A	Feeling conditions craving, clinging and becoming.
26	Dependent origination is not fatalism because: A. events are uncaused B. changing conditions can interrupt suffering C. God controls karma D. self escapes causation	B	Practice can alter conditioned causes.
27	Madhyamika differs from Vaibhasika because: A. only Madhyamika accepts causation B. only Vaibhasika denies self C. Madhyamika empties dharmas while Vaibhasika treats them as ultimately real D. Vaibhasika denies objects	C	Their dispute concerns dharmas' ultimate status.
28	Safest Yogacara interpretation: A. nothing exists B. it equals Advaita C. it proves creator mind D. it critiques independent objecthood while preserving cognitive order	D	This avoids crude nihilism and false equation.
29	Nyaya recognition objection says: A. "this is that" requires enduring identity B. perception is false C. universals are momentary D. memory proves emptiness	A	Pratyabhijna pressures stream theories.
30	Buddhist reply on auxiliaries: A. auxiliaries are unreal B. changed causal complex does the work if cause is unchanged C. permanent things cannot coexist D. all effects are simultaneous	B	It challenges an unchanged cause's contribution.
31	No-self is not annihilationism because: A. subtle ego remains B. persons never die C. causal and conventional continuity remains D. nirvana is material survival	C	Substance-self is denied, not process.
32	Best verdict: A. schools share nothing B. sunyata is nothingness C. ethics is impossible D. Buddhism replaces substance-identity with causal continuity, though ownership objections remain	D	It captures the strength and residual pressure.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Explain why pratityasamutpada is simultaneously a theory of causation and a method of liberation.

Model solution

Pratityasamutpada explains causation by showing that conditioned phenomena arise and cease with supporting conditions. It is soteriological because suffering is one such conditioned process. Avidya generates formations, craving and clinging; removing these conditions prevents renewed becoming.

Its practical significance is that the chain is interruptible, especially at the movement from feeling to craving. Wisdom sees impermanence and no-self; morality and meditation alter the affective conditions of the stream.

Verdict: It is not a neutral cosmology later applied to salvation. Its causal grammar reveals both why suffering arises and how it can cease.

Why this earns marks: It states both dimensions, identifies an intervention point, and concludes with their internal unity.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Compare Vaibhasika, Sautrantika, Yogacara and Madhyamika as answers to the problem of the object of knowledge.

Model solution

School	Object position	Knowledge relation	Main pressure
Vaibhasika	external dharman are real	directly perceived	direct access to momentary objects
Sautrantika	external objects are real	inferred from mental forms	copy cannot prove unknown original
Yogacara	independent external object denied	cognition presents subject and object	shared experience
Madhyamika	mind and object lack svabhava	claims operate conventionally	self-refutation charge

The movement is not a ladder in which one school simply wins. Vaibhasika protects causal realism; Sautrantika recognizes mediation; Yogacara exposes experience's mind-structured character; Madhyamika criticizes reification of both object and consciousness.

Verdict: The debate shifts from *which object is known* to *whether knower or known possesses intrinsic nature*. Madhyamika is most radical but depends on conventional truth to preserve inquiry.

Why this earns marks: It compares all four on one axis, gives each strength and objection, and avoids presenting the sequence as mere chronology.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Buddhist process ontology secures change more successfully than it secures responsibility." Critically examine.

Model solution

Buddhist process ontology explains change powerfully. Pratityasamutpada replaces static substance with conditional arising; ksanikavada explains causal novelty through moment-specific efficacy; nairatmyavada removes an unchanging owner incompatible with experiential flux.

Responsibility is harder. Karma requires that an intentional act and its later fruit belong together. Buddhism answers through santana, transmitted dispositions, pratisandhana and, in Yogacara, alaya-vijnana with karmic seeds. The later recipient is neither identical with nor unrelated to the agent.

This blocks the crude charges of lost action and undeserved result. Ordinary responsibility already tracks psychological and causal continuity despite bodily and mental change. Madhyamika argues that agency operates

conventionally and never required ultimate substance.

Yet causal connection explains why event B follows A more readily than why B's suffering is *my* fruit. Nyaya treats memory and appropriation as evidence of an enduring subject. Alaya-vijnana improves continuity but risks resembling a disguised self.

The Buddhist reply is that "mine" is itself constructed within an integrated stream. Responsibility is preserved by appropriate causal inheritance, not metaphysical ownership.

Verdict: Buddhism explains change better than substance theories that leave alteration mysterious. Its account of responsibility is coherent but less decisive because the move from causal continuity to ownership remains contestable.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates both halves, names multiple continuity devices, includes Nyaya's strongest challenge, and reaches a qualified verdict.

FINAL CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES - SCHOOLS OF BUDDHISM

Causal Core

- Pratityasamutpada: conditioned arising and conditioned cessation.
- Four Noble Truths give its soteriological frame.
- Twelve links: avidya to jara-marana.
- Middle way: neither eternalism nor annihilationism.
- Interruption is possible because causes are conditioned.

Derivation Spine

DEPENDENCE -> IMPERMANENCE -> MOMENTARINESS
-> NO SUBSTANTIAL SELF
-> CRAVING CAN CEASE
-> NIRVANA

Momentariness

- Real = causally efficacious: *sat = arthakriya-samartha*.
- Permanent cause dilemma: all effects simultaneously or different powers successively.
- Sahakarin objection: unchanged cause contributes no temporally specific explanation.
- Santana explains continuity without numerical identity.
- Main criticism: memory, recognition and ownership appear to require one subject.

No-Self

- Five skandhas: rupa, vedana, samjna, samskara, vijnana.
- Chariot analogy: person is conventionally designated upon parts/processes.
- Pudgala-nairatmya denies personal substance.
- Dharma-nairatmya denies intrinsic nature even to constituent dharmas.
- No-self is not non-existence of conventional persons.

Four Schools Matrix

School	External world	Key formula	Main objection
Vaibhasika	directly perceived and real	direct realism	access to momentary dharmas
Sautrantika	real but inferred	representational realism	copy cannot prove original
Yogacara	independent external object denied	vijnaptimatra	intersubjective order
Madhyamika	empty of svabhava	sunyata and two truths	nihilism/self-refutation

Yogacara

- Alaya-vijnana stores bija and vasana.
- Dream and atom/whole arguments challenge external objects.
- Three natures: parikalpita, paratantra, parinispanna.
- Safer verdict: critique of independent objecthood, not "nothing exists."

Madhyamika

- Dependently arisen = empty of svabhava.
- Sunyata does not deny conventional efficacy.
- Two truths: samvrti and paramartha.
- Catuskoti: is, is not, both, neither.
- Emptiness of emptiness blocks reification.

Buddhist Epistemology

- Dignaga-Dharmakirti: perception and inference.
- Perception is non-conceptual and non-errant.
- Svalaksana: unique causally effective particular.
- Samanyalaksana: conceptual/general construction.
- Apoha: meaning by exclusion of the other.
- Pramana and result are phases of one cognitive event.

Karma, Memory and Responsibility

- Experience leaves dispositions in the stream.
- Sautrantika: seed-like potency.
- Yogacara: alaya-vijnana and bija.
- Across moments: neither strict identity nor complete difference.
- Nyaya pressure: causal succession may not equal ownership.

Nirvana

- Cessation of ignorance, craving and karmic production.
- Not survival of an eternal ego.
- Ksanikavada applies to conditioned phenomena; nirvana is unconditioned or cessation.
- Madhyamika: do not reify nirvana into a second substance.

PYQ Route Map

- 2018: dependent origination to emptiness; no-self and nirvana.
- 2019: Yogacara external-world critique; dependence to momentariness.
- 2020: full derivation of momentariness; skandhas and liberation.
- 2021: two no-self doctrines; memory and identity.
- 2022: karma compatibility; Triratna and no-self.
- 2023: dependent origination as soteriology.
- 2024: "void" versus "real" from one causal doctrine.
- 2025: nirvana with momentariness and no-self.

Answer Spines

10 marks: define -> three-step argument -> one distinction -> verdict.

15 marks: doctrine -> derivation/table -> objection and reply -> qualified conclusion.

20 marks: conceptual frame -> full causal logic -> school comparison -> named criticism -> balanced verdict.

Final Traps

1. Sunyata is not sheer nothingness.
2. Nairatmyavada denies permanent self, not conventional personhood.
3. Momentariness denies enduring substance, not causal continuity.
4. Vaibhasika and Sautrantika are realist schools.
5. Yogacara should not be casually equated with Advaita.
6. Alaya-vijnana is a continuity device, not an admitted eternal soul.
7. Pudgala-nairatmya and dharma-nairatmya are not synonyms.
8. Nirvana is not annihilation of a permanent person.
9. The two truths do not mean one truth is simply false.
10. Contemporary Buddhist diplomacy is linkage, never proof of doctrine.